MILLENNIUMPOST.IN

RNI NO.: DELENG/2005/15351

millenniumpost

NO HALF TRUTHS

PUBLISHED FROM DELHI | KOLKATA | SILIGURI

VOL.21, ISSUE 155 | Friday, 5 June, 2026 | New Delhi | Pages 12 | Rs 4.00

CITY: PG 2
CM Gupta reviews preps; hints hike in funds for organising committees

NATION: PG 5
Shivakumar rolls out grievance redressal set-up

FILM: PG 12
Paramvir opens up about 'The Pyramid Scheme'

PM MODI HOLDS TALKS WITH DELCY RODRIGUEZ

Venezuela offers long-term energy ties as India diversifies oil sources

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India and Venezuela on Thursday agreed to work towards a long-term energy partnership as Prime Minister Narendra Modi held wide-ranging talks with Venezuelan Acting President Delcy Rodríguez, with both sides identifying oil, mining, critical minerals, pharmaceuticals, agriculture and automobiles as key areas for expanding cooperation. The discussions came at a time when India is increasing efforts to diversify its crude oil imports amid supply disruptions linked to the West Asia crisis, while Venezuela is seeking to strengthen trade and investment ties with one of the world's fastest-growing major economies.

Rodríguez, who arrived in India on Wednesday for a five-day visit, met Modi in New Delhi and conveyed that Venezuela views India as a preferred energy partner because of its large and growing economy and its position as a reliable long-term buyer of energy. Indian officials said the two countries share natural complementarities, with Venezuela possessing vast energy resources and India offering strong demand, refining capabilities and technical expertise.

Secretary (East) in the Ministry of External Affairs Rudrendra Tandon said energy cooperation was a central theme of the talks. "They see India as a stable demander for many years to come. Therefore, there exists a perfect complementarity for India and Venezuela to work in the energy sector, in both upstream and downstream," he told reporters after the meeting.

Continued on P4

Prime Minister Narendra Modi during a bilateral meeting with Venezuela's Acting President Delcy Rodriguez at the Hyderabad House, in New Delhi PTI

TAKEAWAYS

- Rodríguez said Venezuela sees India as a preferred energy partner and a stable long-term buyer of crude oil
- India expressed interest in expanding cooperation across upstream and downstream oil activities, including exploration, production and refining
- Venezuela has become India's third-largest oil supplier, with crude shipments rising sharply since April amid supply disruptions linked to the West Asia crisis
- Oil Minister Hardeep Singh Puri said Indian refiners were among Venezuela's key crude buyers in April-May 2026

Delhi hotel blaze: Victims mourned, guests relocate as probe continues

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: A day after a devastating fire ripped through a budget hotel in south Delhi's Malviya Nagar, investigators intensified their search for answers as grieving families mourned 21 victims, residents struggled to come to terms with the tragedy and authorities announced compensation for those affected by one of the Capital's deadliest fire disasters in recent years.

As the investigation gathered pace, hotel owner Lavkesh Bajaj remained at the centre of the probe. Delhi Police arrested him on Wednesday evening and registered a case that includes charges of culpable homicide not amounting to murder.

On Thursday, a Delhi court granted police four days' custody of Bajaj, accepting investigators' contention that further questioning was required to examine the hotel's operations, recover documents and identify other individuals whose roles may be relevant to the case. Police are also searching for hotel manager Jai Mishra and examining the roles of other staff members connected to the establishment.

Authorities said the investigation would focus on determining how the fire started, whether safety regulations were violated and whether lapses in compliance contributed to the scale of the disaster.

The blaze broke out at the Flourish Stay Continued on P4

Relatives of Chartered Accountant Vivek Aggarwal, his wife, two daughters, mother and other relatives, who lost their lives in Malviya Nagar fire incident, mourn as the mortal remains of victims reach, in Gurugram, on Thursday PTI

KEY POINTS

- Probe focuses on alleged fire-safety violations, illegal construction, building norm breaches and evacuation failures
- Authorities are also verifying reports of unauthorised additional floors
- Investigators found the establishment allegedly had approval for six rooms but was operating around 25 rooms, including basement accommodation
- Delhi govt to pay Rs 10 lakh to kin of deceased, Rs 5 lakh to seriously injured

TEMPERATURES DROP BY UP TO 19°C

Rain, gusty winds lash Delhi-NCR; IMD issues red alert for Capital

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Heavy rain, thunderstorms and strong winds swept across Delhi and the National Capital Region on Thursday, bringing relief from days of intense heat and causing temperatures to plunge sharply in several parts of the city. As weather conditions worsened during the day, the India Meteorological Department (IMD) upgraded its warning for Delhi from a yellow alert to a red alert, while issuing an orange alert for neighbouring Ghaziabad, Noida, Faridabad and Gurugram.

Dark clouds covered the city on Thursday afternoon before heavy showers and gusty winds moved in across several areas. According to IMD data, some locations recorded dramatic Continued on P4

A metal boundary fence falls on parked cars after rainfall and gusty winds, in Noida, on Thursday PTI

Southwest monsoon arrives in Kerala

NEW DELHI: The southwest monsoon set over Kerala on Thursday, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD).

Typically, the monsoon arrives in Kerala around June 1, which marks the beginning of the southwest monsoon season (June-September).

"The southwest monsoon has Continued on P4

India fixes jet fuel benchmark at Rs 115/l

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Domestic airlines will be able to purchase aviation turbine fuel (ATF) at a fixed benchmark price for up to three years under a new government-backed scheme aimed at protecting carriers and passengers from sharp swings in global fuel costs triggered by the ongoing West Asia crisis.

The Union Cabinet has approved a Rs 10,000-crore fuel price stabilisation programme under which participating airlines can buy jet fuel at a fixed free-on-board (FOB) benchmark rate of Rs 86.32 per litre for domestic operations and Rs 104.49 per litre for international services.

Continued on P4

Five killed in fire at private hospital in Bihar's Muzaffarpur

MUZAFFARPUR: At least five people lost their lives and several others were injured after a fire broke out in the intensive care unit (ICU) of a private hospital in Bihar's Muzaffarpur district in the early hours of Thursday, officials said. The blaze erupted around 3 am at Prasad Hospital in the Brahmpura area and rapidly engulfed the ICU, filling the ward with thick smoke.

See P4

DMK to boycott India bloc meet on June 8 in New Delhi

MPOST BUREAU

CHENNAI: Tamil Nadu's opposition DMK on Thursday announced that it will skip the INDIA bloc meeting scheduled in New Delhi on June 8, citing anger among its cadre over the Congress party's decision to align with the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) government after the recent Assembly election.

In a statement, the DMK said its workers remained "deeply hurt" by what they viewed as a betrayal by the Congress, a long-time ally of the Dravidian party. "In view of the sentiments of the DMK cadres who continue to feel deeply hurt by what they consider as betrayal by the Congress party against the DMK, the party will not take part in the INDIA bloc meeting in New Delhi on June 8 in which the Congress Continued on P4

BJP, Congress unveil Rajya Sabha candidates ahead of June 18 polls

Kharge, Pawan Khera among Congress nominees; BJP drops Bittu and Kurian

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Congress on Thursday unveiled their candidates for the June 18 Rajya Sabha elections, setting the stage for contests across several states while also triggering political discussions over possible changes in the Union Council of Ministers after the BJP left out two serving ministers from its list.

The BJP announced 11 candidates for Rajya Sabha polls in five states, nominating senior leaders Tarun Chugh from Madhya Pradesh and Satish Poonia from Rajasthan. The party also fielded Debashish Samantaray from Odisha, Rajneesh Agrawal from Madhya Pradesh, Alka Gurjar from Rajasthan, A Sharda Devi from Manipur and Tai Tagak from Arunachal Pradesh.

Continued on P4

CENTRE REACHES OUT TO DMK, TMC MPs

Delimitation Bill back on govt agenda

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Modi government is likely to reintroduce the Delimitation Bill during the upcoming Monsoon Session of Parliament and has begun discussions with regional parties in a bid to build consensus on the issue, sources said on Thursday.

Sources said that the Centre has reached out to parties like the DMK and the Trinamool Congress as part of its efforts to reintroduce the Bill. Several TMC MPs have responded positively to the government's approach and are open to discussions on delimitation, sources added.

The DMK, which has been vocal about concerns surrounding the exercise, has also not displayed rigidity during consultations and is awaiting the government's revised draft of the Bill, sources said. The government outreach to regional parties is significant as it remains keen and hopeful on securing broader issue-based support before bringing back the legislation to Parliament.

Earlier this year, a united opposition had dealt a blow to the government's proposed constitutional amendments as they failed to garner the required two-thirds majority.

Sources said the government remains "very keen" on reviving the two measures and believes support could come from MPs across party lines, including regional outfits and opposition parties.

Out of 528 members who participated in the vote, 298 backed the Bill while 230 opposed it. It fell short of the 352 votes the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) needed to secure the required two-thirds majority.

The Bill had aimed to bypass the requirement of a new Census for delimitation, a provision that has remained central to the rollout of women's quota in legislatures.

The Centre's fresh push on delimitation underlines the government's keenness to complete the exercise before the 2029 Lok Continued on P4

HIGHLIGHTS

- Government has initiated consultations with regional parties to build consensus before bringing the Bill back
- Outreach has reportedly included the DMK and the Trinamool Congress (TMC)
- Several TMC MPs have responded positively and are open to discussions on the proposal, sources said
- DMK, despite raising concerns over delimitation, has not taken a rigid stand and is awaiting the government's revised draft

KANWAR YATRA

CM Gupta reviews preps; hints hike in funds for organising committees

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta issued instructions on Thursday to ensure the smooth conduct of the Kanwar Yatra, hinting that the funds provided by the Delhi government to the organising committee may be increased if necessary.

Gupta reviewed preparations for the annual religious event held during the monsoon season in a meeting with several Kanwar committees.

After assessing the arrangements, she directed officials to initiate the registration process for these committees on time and to ensure that all preparations are in place so that registrations can commence from July 1, according to a statement from the Chief Minister's Office (CMO).

During the meeting, representatives from the Kanwar committees expressed that the current grant amount from the Delhi government is inadequate for larger camps due to rising costs of tents and other essential arrangements.

Some committees suggested either increasing the grant amount or reinstating the previous system where the government directly provided tents. Responding to the suggestions, Chief Minister Gupta assured the representatives that the government would consider all proposals positively and that the grant amount could be adjusted if needed, the statement said.

The Delhi government has intensified preparations for the Kanwar Yatra, which will include round-the-clock medical assistance, security measures, mobile toilets, and flower showers for the thousands of devotees travelling from Delhi and neighbouring areas to Haridwar during this religious event. The revenue department reported that 308 Kanwar camps successfully operated across Delhi last year. For the first time, Kanwar committees were granted funds last year. The government provided grants ranging from Rs 50,000 to Rs 10 lakh to these committees through a direct benefit transfer mechanism to help set up camps for devotees.

During the Kanwar Yatra, devotees of Lord Shiva cover long distances on foot while carrying holy water from the Ganges in Haridwar to offer it at the deity's temples.

TAKEAWAYS

» After assessing the arrangements, she directed officials to initiate the registration process for these committees on time and to ensure that all preps are in place so that registrations can commence from July 1, according to a statement

» Representatives from the Kanwar committees expressed that the current grant amount from Delhi govt is inadequate for larger camps due to rising costs of tents...

Delhi court defers verdict in IB officer murder case for June 11

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court on Thursday deferred its verdict in the sensational murder case of Intelligence Bureau officer Ankit Sharma during the 2020 northeast Delhi riots for June 11.

Additional Sessions Judge Praveen Singh was hearing the case against 11 accused, including former AAP councillor Tahir Hussain, and deferred the pronouncement of his judgment.

The case pertains to an FIR registered at Dayalpur police station on the complaint of Ravinder Kumar, father of Ankit Sharma. According to the complaint, Sharma, who was posted with the Intelligence Bureau, had returned home from office on February 25, 2020, before stepping out again.

When he did not return for a long time, his family began searching for him, only to be informed by locals that their son had been killed and his body thrown into the Khajuri Khas drain near a mosque in the Chand Bagh Pulia area.

> When he did not return for a long time, his family began searching for him, only to be informed that he had been killed

Sharma's body was subsequently recovered from the drain.

In his complaint, Kumar alleged that his son was murdered by former AAP councillor Tahir Hussain and others. It said they had allegedly assembled at Hussain's office, and Ankit's body was disposed of after the murder.

On March 24, 2023, a Delhi court framed charges against Hussain and 10 others.

The other accused include Haseen alias Mullaji alias Salman, Nazim, Kasim, Sameer Khan, Anas, Firoz, Javed, Gulfam, Shoaib Alam alias Bobby, and Muntajim alias Musa.

The accused were charged under Indian Penal Code sections pertaining to rioting, rioting armed with deadly weapons, promoting enmity between groups, murder and criminal conspiracy. Hussain was additionally charged with abetment and statements conducive to public mischief.

The case stems from the communal violence that erupted in northeast Delhi in February 2020 during protests against the Citizenship (Amendment) Act.

The clashes, marked by incidents of stone-pelting, arson and vandalism, had left 53 people dead and several others injured.

Delhi University assistant professor found murdered

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 49-year-old assistant professor of a college under Delhi University was found murdered in her apartment in east Delhi's Vasundhara Enclave on Thursday afternoon, police said.

The victim, identified as Devosmita Paul, an assistant professor at Shivaji College, was living alone in the flat in Vasundhara Enclave, Deputy Commissioner of Police (East) Rajeev Kumar said in an official statement.

Police said they received a PCR call at around 2.35 pm from a woman who reported that her sister had been murdered and was lying inside the flat. A police team rushed to the spot, where the caller, identified as Devarati Paul, informed officers that her sister had not been responding to repeated phone calls since morning.

She said the apartment was locked from the outside and, suspecting something untoward, she broke open the lock and entered the flat. She then found her sister lying dead inside the residence and alerted the police. The crime team and forensic experts were called to the scene. A detailed examination of the apartment was conducted and relevant exhibits and forensic samples were collected. The crime scene was photographed and videographed as part of the investigation, police said.

> The victim, identified as Devosmita Paul, an assistant professor at Shivaji College, was living alone in the flat in Vasundhara Enclave

The body has been shifted to Lal Bahadur Shastri Hospital for post-mortem. The exact cause of death will be ascertained after receiving the autopsy report, officials said.

A case has been registered under Section 103(1) (murder) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita at New Ashok Nagar police station. Police said multiple teams have been formed to identify and apprehend the accused. Investigators are examining all possible angles, including the victim's recent movements, contacts and CCTV footage from the area. Further investigation is underway.

Yamuna eway stretch in Gautam Buddha Nagar entirely declared 'no protest zone'

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

NOIDA: The entire stretch of the Yamuna Expressway falling under Gautam Buddha Nagar district has been declared a 'no protest zone' to ensure smooth and obstruction-free movement of traffic, police said on Thursday.

The restriction applies to the 41-km stretch of the expressway within the jurisdiction of Gautam Buddh Nagar, police said. The Gautam Buddh Nagar Police Commissionerate said the decision was taken in compliance with the directions issued by the Allahabad High Court on May 22.

The move comes after a series of protests in the Noida-Greater Noida region in the recent months by industrial workers.

Following the declaration, political, non-political and other forms of protests and demonstrations on the Yamuna Expressway have been prohibited, officials said.

The move aims to ensure uninterrupted movement of commuters and commercial vehicles and prevent traffic disruptions on the expressway, police said.

"Information boards regarding the order are being installed at key locations along the expressway, at the police commissionerate office and at relevant police stations. The information is also being disseminated through various media platforms to create public awareness," police said.

The police said strict compliance with the order was being ensured and continuous surveillance was being maintained on the expressway to uphold law and order and effective traffic management.

The industrial workers in Noida recently held demonstrations over their demands, including wage hike, while farmer groups in Greater Noida have repeatedly staged protests over land compensation and other issues, at times affecting traffic movement on major routes.

Four sustain burns after LPG cylinder blast in Nabi Karim

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Four people sustained burn injuries after an LPG cylinder burst at a small food stall operating from a house in central Delhi's Nabi Karim area on Thursday morning, police and fire officials said.

The incident was reported at 9.29 am at a house in Amarpuri, following which personnel from Delhi Police and Delhi Fire Services (DFS) rushed to the spot. According to police, the incident occurred in a small room on the ground floor of the house that was being used by Sarita, 35, to prepare and sell tea and simple meals such as dal-rice.

Preliminary enquiry revealed that Sarita had asked a man, identified as Krishan, 37, to replace an LPG cylinder. While the regulator was being opened, a sudden fire broke out.

Fire officials, however, said an LPG cylinder burst occurred in the food stall, measuring approximately 6x8 square feet, resulting in burn injuries to four people.

All the injured were shifted to Ram Manohar Lohia (RML) Hospital by PCR and CATS ambulances before the arrival of fire tenders and were admitted under the supervision of Dr Shruti, officials said.

The injured have been identified as Sarita, wife of Ram Sevak, who sustained around 50 per cent burns; Ajay, 19, son of Ram Kishan, who suffered about 40 per cent burns; Zakir, 35, son of Irfan, who sustained around 30 per cent burns; and Krishan, son of Ramji, who suffered about 40 per cent burn injuries.

Police said Ajay was present at the stall for tea when the incident occurred, while Zakir, a resident of Amarpuri, was passing through the area at the time.

A fire officer who inspected the site said the blaze originated in the food stall area and was linked to the LPG cylinder burst.

FIRs against 165 staff over Census 2027 non-cooperation

DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: The Gautam Buddh Nagar administration has intensified action against employees allegedly failing to perform duties assigned under Census 2027, with FIRs registered against 165 personnel for non-cooperation and failure to report at designated work locations.

Officials said those booked include 92 teachers and assistant teachers, 43 Anganwadi workers, and 30 employees from various other departments. The action comes amid efforts by the district administration to accelerate the first phase of Census 2027 — the House Listing and Housing Census (HLO), which began on May 22 and will continue till June 20.

According to officials, Gautam Buddh Nagar has identified 2,284 House Listing Blocks (HLBs) for the exercise. Work is currently underway in 1,605 HLBs, while enumeration has been completed in 16 blocks. However, work has yet to begin in 654 HLBs, with administrative data indicating that only around 70 per cent of the designated blocks are currently operational.

District Magistrate and Principal Census Officer Medha Roopam has repeatedly reviewed the progress of census operations and directed authorities to ensure strict monitoring of field-level activities. Earlier this week, officials also sought police action against dozens of enumerators in Noida, Greater Noida and the Yamuna Expressway area who allegedly failed to collect duty orders or report for work despite repeated reminders.

The administration has described Census 2027 as a mandatory national exercise requiring timely completion. Officials warned that negligence or refusal to perform census duties would invite disciplinary and legal action under relevant provisions of the Census Act. Similar action against absentee enumerators has also been reported, reflecting the government's push to ensure smooth implementation of India's first fully digital census.

Authorities have directed assigned personnel to immediately join duty, warning that delays in census operations will attract responsibility and action against the concerned employee.

Mandoli jail inmate dies; inquiry on

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 40-year-old inmate lodged in Mandoli jail died after he was taken to the Guru Teg Bahadur Hospital in northeast Delhi in an unconscious state, police said on Thursday.

Information regarding the admission of the inmate was received at Harsh Vihar police station from the hospital on June 3; doctors declared him brought dead, police said.

The deceased was identified as Malkeet Singh, a resident of Azadpur's Lal Bagh area.

According to police, Singh was lodged in Mandoli jail in connection with a case under the Arms Act registered by the Special Cell in 2021 and a murder case registered in Punjab's Fatehgarh Sahib district. The body has been sent for a post-mortem examination to ascertain the cause of death, police said.

An inquiry under Section 196 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) has been initiated, and further proceedings are underway, they added.

Narela DDA residents allege fire safety system remains defunct despite repeated complaints

SHIVANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: Residents of DDA flats in Narela Pocket-1C, covering Sectors A1 to A4, have alleged serious lapses in fire safety infrastructure, claiming that fire lines within the housing complex were removed and have remained non-functional despite repeated complaints and RTI applications.

The issue came to light through posts on X, where residents questioned the authorities responsible for maintaining fire safety systems in the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) housing society. They alleged that officials failed to respond to complaints or take corrective action.

According to residents, representations were submitted to several senior officials, including those in the DDA and Delhi Fire Service (DFS). They claimed that while information was sought under the Right to Information (RTI) Act, no visible action followed on the ground.

KEY POINTS

» The issue came to light through posts on X, where residents questioned the authorities responsible for maintaining fire safety systems

» The allegations have renewed concerns over fire safety in residential complexes, particularly in the wake of recent fire incidents in the Capital. Residents have demanded a thorough inquiry

The allegations have renewed concerns over fire safety in residential complexes, particularly in the wake of recent fire incidents in the Capital. Residents have demanded an inquiry into the alleged removal of fire safety infrastructure and accountability for officials responsible for its maintenance.

Attempts were made to contact DDA officials for a response, but no comment was received till the filing of this report.

Delhi Police adds 32 PCR vehicles

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police on Tuesday inducted 32 new Police Control Room (PCR) Mobile Patrol Vehicles (MPVs) to strengthen emergency response and enhance policing across the Capital.

The vehicles were flagged off by Special Commissioner of Police David Lalrinsanga from the Police Headquarters on Jai Singh Road.

They have been deployed across 12 districts, including South, South West, West, Rohini, Outer, North East, Shahdara, East, South East and Central Delhi.

Officials said the additional vehicles would improve police mobility, expand area coverage and reduce response times, particularly in areas receiving a high volume of PCR calls.

The induction is aimed at boosting operational readiness and ensuring quicker assistance to citizens in distress.

With the addition, Delhi Police's PCR fleet has increased from 857 to 889 MPVs.

NDMC to hold Suvidha Camp

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) will organise its monthly Suvidha Camp at the NDCC Convention Centre on Jai Singh Road on June 6 from 10.30 a.m. to 12.30 p.m.

The initiative aims to strengthen citizen engagement and ensure prompt redressal of civic grievances.

Residents, Resident Welfare Associations, Market Traders Associations, and serving and retired NDMC employees can seek assistance on issues related to electricity, property tax, birth and death certificates, sanitation, road repairs, pension schemes, and bookings of Barat Ghars and public parks.

Officials from various departments will staff dedicated help desks to provide on-the-spot assistance.

NDMC said the camp, held on the first Saturday of every month, complements its Jan Suvidha Portal, which enables citizens to register and track complaints online.

Delhi Police, MCD launch drive against illegal parking

Joint enforcement campaign targets illegal parking near six multi-level parking sites

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police, in coordination with the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), has launched a joint enforcement and awareness drive against illegal parking around designated multi-level parking facilities across the Capital.

The initiative aims to ease traffic congestion, improve road safety and encourage motorists to use authorised parking infrastructure instead of leaving vehicles in unauthorised locations.

The drive, which began this week, covers six multi-level parking facilities located at Spark Mall in Kamla Nagar, M-Block Market in Greater Kailash-I, Hauz Khas, Qutub Road, Nizamuddin Basti and Parade Ground. Officials said that despite the availability of parking spaces, many motorists continue to park on roadsides, footpaths, service lanes, carriageways and other no-parking zones, obstructing traffic and causing inconvenience to pedestrians.

> Delhi Traffic Police, MCD teams will jointly monitor identified areas and take action against violations

Delhi Traffic Police and MCD teams will jointly monitor the identified areas and take action against violations. Awareness campaigns are also being conducted among residents, visitors, shopkeepers, market associations and resident welfare associations to promote the use of authorised parking facilities.

Authorities have warned that vehicles found parked illegally near these locations may be challaned, towed away or wheel-clamped under the relevant legal provisions. Officials said the campaign is aimed not only at enforcement but also at encouraging behavioural change and greater public cooperation, adding that strict action will continue against repeat offenders.

Printed and Published by Jaiyendra Kumar Sharma on behalf of Front Row Media Pvt. Ltd. and printed at The Indian Express Pvt. Ltd., A-8, Sector-7, Noida-201 301 (U.P.) and published from First Floor, Pratap Bhawan, 5 Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg, New Delhi 110 002. Editor: Durbar Ganguly. Email: editor@millenniumpost.in, Tel. No. 011-47777500, Kolkata office: Room No 1,15th Floor, Chatterjee International Centre, 33A Jawaharlal Nehru Road, Kolkata 700071 West Bengal, Siliguri Office: Techno India Group Zonal Office G-212, 2nd Floor Office Block - City Centre Matigara District Darjeeling Pin - 734010 Phone- 0353- 2576321

HOTEL OWNER DROVE PAST BLAZE SITE

'Sab chalta hai': Greed behind illegal expansion

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: "Delhi me sab chalta hai" (everything works in Delhi). This is what the owner of the Malviya Nagar hotel told police when confronted about major violations. He showed little remorse, even driving past the burning building without stopping during rescue operations following a blaze that claimed 21 lives, including 12 foreign nationals, and left several others injured, officials said on Thursday.

According to police, the accused, Lavkesh Bajaj, is non-cooperative during interrogation. He was arrested following the tragedy at Flourish Stay B&B in south Delhi's Hauz Rani area on Wednesday, one of the deadliest fires in the capital in recent years. Police questioning has revealed what investigators describe as a pattern of greed, regulatory violations and disregard for safety norms.

Police sources said Bajaj told investigators that after the hotel business began generating substantial profits, the belief that "everything works in Delhi" encouraged him to illegally expand the property from two-and-a-half storeys to five floors.

Officials said the property didn't have a licence for a restaurant; it was only permitted to operate as a tea shop. Originally permitted to operate only six rooms under Delhi government's bed-and-breakfast policy, the establishment allegedly expanded to around 25-26 rooms, including some in the basement. Police said rooms were rented for between Rs 3,000 and Rs 15,000 a day, while additional income came from a ground-floor restaurant.

Investigators found that Bajaj allegedly obtained licences in the name of Jai Mishra, who managed the hotel's operations and accounts.

Five police teams are tracing Mishra, who is absconding.

Sources said the building had earlier received a temporary accommodation licence during the 2010 Commonwealth Games under a different owner when the city was facing a shortage of rooms.

During interrogation, Bajaj told investigators he owned at least four hotels in the area and rarely visited them. Police sources said he claimed to have handed over the establishment's day-to-day management to Mishra after purchasing the building in 2022.

Lokesh Bajaj, owner of the hotel where 21 people were killed in a fire incident on Wednesday, brought to the Malviya Nagar Police Station after the Saket court sent him to four days' police custody, in New Delhi, on Thursday PTI

HIGHLIGHTS

- » According to police, the accused, Lavkesh Bajaj, is non-cooperative during interrogation
- » Police sources said Bajaj told investigators that after the hotel business began generating substantial profits, the belief that 'everything works in Delhi' encouraged him to illegally expand the property from two-and-a-half storeys to 5 floors

Investigators alleged that when the fire broke out, Bajaj happened to be passing near the building but did not stop despite noticing the commotion. Instead, he allegedly left the area and kept moving across different parts of Delhi before being tracked down and arrested later that day.

Joint Commissioner of Police (Southern Range) Vijay Kumar said they have got his four days' police remand. "We will ask him about the staff members who were present there as all of them are absconding," he said.

He said the sections of the FIR are correct and multiple sections have been added due to the act and circumstance of the incident. He also said many violations were noted.

"The premises had permission for only six rooms, but there were 25 rooms. No gas connection was taken in the name of the premises, but four cylinders were present," he said.

The probe has now widened beyond the immediate cause of the fire, with investigators examining alleged illegal construction, fire safety violations, licence irregularities, ownership records and factors that may have contributed to the high death toll.

CM orders fire safety audit; Rs 10L relief for kin

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In the aftermath of the devastating Malviya Nagar fire tragedy that claimed 21 lives, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday announced financial assistance for victims' families, ordered a comprehensive audit of fire safety standards across the Capital, and assured full government support to those affected.

During a visit to a hospital in Saket, where several injured victims are undergoing treatment, Gupta met patients and their family members, reviewed their medical condition with doctors, and directed hospital authorities to ensure the best possible treatment without any lapse. "The Delhi Government stands with the affected families with full sensitivity and commitment during this difficult time," the Chief Minister said.

CM visits hospital to meet those injured in the tragic fire incident MPOST

Announcing relief measures, Gupta said the families of those who lost their lives in the fire would receive an ex gratia payment of Rs 10 lakh, while those who suffered serious injuries would be given financial assistance of Rs 5 lakh. She also directed officials to make arrangements for the dignified transportation of mortal remains of victims whose families reside in other states or abroad. The Chief Minister stated that some of the injured patients remain in critical condition, while others have been placed on ventilator support. She was informed that the victims include citizens from Bangladesh, Nepal, Cameroon and Libya, in addition to Indian nationals. Gupta directed the hospital administration to ensure the best possible medical care for all patients and instructed officials to maintain necessary coordination in cases involving foreign nationals. "Every patient must receive the highest standard of treatment and all required assistance without any delay," she said. While interacting with the injured, the Chief Minister assured them of all possible support from the government for their recovery. She sought individual updates on each patient and instructed doctors to maintain continuous monitoring of their treatment.

Gupta also lauded the efforts of local residents, hotel staff, police personnel and volunteers who participated in rescue operations. According to information shared with her, several people were rescued from the burning building, while CPR was administered to multiple victims at the scene. "Their courage, prompt response and humanitarian spirit during the crisis were highly commendable," she said, directing officials to identify and honour individuals who played a significant role in the rescue efforts.

The Chief Minister said preliminary findings had revealed serious safety lapses. "In many buildings, information regarding emergency exits, fire safety systems and other safety arrangements does not adequately reach occupants," she said. Gupta ordered a detailed probe into the incident and directed departments to undertake a special audit of fire safety norms in hotels, commercial establishments and other public buildings across Delhi. She warned that strict action would be taken wherever negligence or violations are established.

L-G: 'Target, halt & dismantle' unauthorised constructions

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi L-G Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Thursday directed MCD officials to come up with a plan to "target, halt and dismantle" unauthorised constructions in the city, Lok Niwas officials said. Chairing a high-level review meeting of Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) Sandhu emphasised on a comprehensive action plan for stronger urban governance, improved civic infrastructure and enhanced structural safety across the capital.

"The L-G emphasised on executing a comprehensive action plan to target, halt, and dismantle unauthorised constructions. He asked for a regulatory framework that ensures strict enforcement of building bylaws, penalizing illegal constructions, expansions and fixes absolute institutional accountability across all municipal zones," an official said.

Delhi L-G also directed for "strict enforcement" of building bylaws to curb illegal structural expansions and directed the MCD to implement a time-bound strategy to tackle unauthorised constructions decisively. The directions come in the wake of a major fire tragedy in Delhi's Malviya Nagar on Wednesday that claimed 21 lives and rendered 25 other, including foreigners, injured.

"The MCD will initiate a high-intensity, time-bound strategy mandating the complete detection and sealing or demolition of all ongoing and existing unauthorised constructions within a strict timeframe," the official added. Sandhu has also given directions to come up with a stringent action plan to identify, process, and curb illegal residential and commercial vertical expansions that violate approved building blueprints or standard safety codes.

MCD to seek cancellation of licences of 12 Hauz Rani B&Bs

NEW DELHI: The MCD will write to the Tourism department to cancel licences for 12 bed-and-breakfast (B&B) facilities operating in Hauz Rani, a day after a devastating fire at a guest house in the locality, officials said on Thursday.

The move comes as civic authorities intensify enforcement measures following the fire at Flourish Stay in Malviya Nagar on Wednesday, which killed 21 people, including 12 foreign nationals, and prompted scrutiny of commercial establishments operating in the area. A senior Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) official said 12 licensed B&B properties have been identified in and around the Hauz Rani locality where the fire incident occurred and they will be sealed once their licences are revoked.

"We have identified 12 such buildings operating in violation of norms. Since they have got licences under the bed-and-breakfast scheme, first we will get those licences cancelled. Once the licences are revoked, we will be able to seal them," the official said. PTI

Fire breaks out in hotel basement in Safdarjung Enclave, doused

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A fire broke out in the basement of a hotel in south Delhi's Safdarjung Enclave on Thursday evening, prompting the deployment of multiple fire tenders, officials said.

The Delhi Fire Services received a call regarding the blaze at around 7 pm from a hotel near the NCC Office and Jaat Chaupal in Humayunpur, Safdarjung Enclave, officials said.

Three water tenders, one water bowser and one breathing apparatus tender were rushed to the spot.

The fire was reported in the hotel's basement and was brought under control by 7.20 pm, officials said.

"No casualties or injuries were reported in the incident. The cause of the fire is yet to be ascertained. Further details are awaited," they added.

Food safety heat: 12 Delhi businesses FACE ACTION

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government's Food Safety Department collected 217 food samples from establishments across the city in May and initiated action against 12 food business operators after their samples did not conform to prescribed standards, according to an official statement issued on Thursday.

During the month, the department received 145 food analysis reports. Of these, 133 samples met food safety standards, while 12 did not comply with the necessary norms, the statement said. Appropriate action has been initiated against the concerned food business operators under the provisions of the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006, it added. According to the statement, a substandard masala manufacturing unit operating in the Khari Baoli market was shut down during a joint operation involving the Food Safety Department officials and the Delhi Police. The operator of this unit is facing legal action under the same Act.

> "Govt is committed to ensuring that every citizen has access to safe and wholesome food
>
> — Health Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh

The statement said the department continued surveillance, inspection and enforcement activities across the national capital during the month to ensure the availability of safe and wholesome food for consumers. Health Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh said the government remained committed to ensuring food safety and would continue taking strict action against violators.

"The Delhi government is committed to ensuring that every citizen has access to safe and wholesome food. The Department of Food Safety is undertaking rigorous surveillance, enforcement and compliance measures across the city," Singh said.

To facilitate compliance and promote ease of doing business, the department processed a large number of licensing and registration applications during May, the statement mentioned.

According to the statement, 503 licenses were granted, while 753 applications for license renewals and modifications were processed.

Additionally, 4,010 registrations were issued, and 1,000 registration applications related to renewals and modifications were processed, it said.

The department said it would continue strengthening its regulatory framework through scientific sampling, targeted inspections, legal enforcement and stakeholder engagement to curb food adulteration and improve food safety standards across Delhi.

DELHI HOTEL FIRE

TILL THE END: African couple found dead in each other's arms

SAUMYA SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: They say "till death do us part", but an African couple could not be separated even by death. The couple, who were undergoing an IVF treatment at a Delhi hospital, were found dead in each other's arms after smoke inhalation claimed their lives along with 19 others in the Malviya Nagar fire tragedy.

The couple, among the 12 foreign nationals killed in Wednesday's blaze at the Flourish Stay B&B in Hauz Rani, were discovered inside a bathroom on the ground floor, where they had apparently taken shelter as thick smoke and flames rapidly engulfed the building.

Hospital staff and local residents familiar with the couple said they had been staying at the facility while receiving fertility treatment at a nearby hospital.

Speaking to PTI, Wasim Raja, a duty in-charge at Max Smart Hospital who was among the first responders, described the scene as one that surpassed even the Taj Mahal as a symbol of love.

"We somehow managed to open the bathroom door and saw something that is beyond words to describe. I have seen many dead bodies during my career, but nothing compares to what I saw there," Raja told PTI.

According to him, the woman, who appeared to have recently undergone a medical procedure and bore a surgery mark on her head, was seated on the toilet seat, while her husband sat on a chair beside her.

"They were holding each other. Their arms were wrapped around one another and her head was resting on his shoulder," he said.

Raja said rescuers immediately checked for signs of life and attempted resuscitation.

"We checked their pulse and veins and tried CPR and every possible life-saving measure, but there was no response. They had most likely succumbed to smoke inhalation," he said.

Even in their final moments, the couple appeared to have sought comfort in each other's presence, he added.

"When death was approaching, they chose to face it together in each other's arms. It was a scene that will stay with me forever," Raja said.

A local cab operator, Ikrar, who lives near the hotel, said several drivers in the area knew the couple as they frequently travelled to and from the nearby hospital for treatment.

"They were undergoing IVF treatment. Drivers from our locality would often ferry them to the hospital and back. They had come here with hope of starting a family," he said. The tragedy unfolded on Wednesday morning when a massive fire swept through the five-storey hotel, killing 21 people and injuring several others. PTI

VISION 2035 GUIDES COLLABORATION

India & UK unveil new initiatives on critical minerals, maritime security

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India and the UK are well-positioned to construct a new future-oriented and mutually beneficial partnership on the back of their newly firmed-up comprehensive trade deal and the defence industrial roadmap, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said on Thursday.

He made the remarks during a meeting with visiting British Foreign Secretary Yvette Cooper. In new initiatives, the two sides concluded a memorandum of understanding (MoU) on setting up the Regional Maritime Security Centre of Excellence, which will help Indian Ocean states to build capacity to address non-traditional maritime security threats. The centre will be set up by King's College London and the National Maritime Foundation. India and the UK also announced the launch of Critical Minerals Global Supply Chain Observatory (GSCO) to boost cooperation in critical minerals and support the creation of resilient and secure global supply chains. Cooper also met Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

"Appreciated the deepening of the India-UK partnership in recent times that has unlocked unprecedented growth opportunities for both our countries. India-UK Vision 2035 will continue to guide our partnership and strengthen our joint efforts for global good," Modi said on social media. After the meeting, Jaishankar said both sides "reviewed ongoing progress in our cooperation focusing on trade, technology, supply chains, defence, climate, education and people to people ties. Also spoke about new opportunities in clean energy, AI and critical minerals".

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Jaishankar said CETA addresses many concerns about creating resilient supply chains and addressing concerns in areas of trade, energy...
- » 'Our relationship moved from being a historical and perhaps cultural connection to being a forward-looking highway of shared ambitions'

Five ICU patients die after fire breaks out at pvt hosp

MUZAFFARPUR/PATNA: Five patients choked to death at a private hospital in Muzaffarpur district of Bihar on Thursday after smoke filled the ICU following a fire incident, and the staff allegedly ran away leaving those admitted there in the lurch, a top official said.

A short circuit apparently triggered the fire in the hospital, and the district administration formed a committee to look into the matter.

Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary directed the authorities to pay an ex-gratia of Rs four lakh to the next of kin of each deceased.

The rescue operations began within four minutes of receipt of information that there was a fire at Prasad Hospital, situated in Brahmapura locality of the north Bihar town, Shobha Ahotkar, the Director General (Fire), told PTI Video in the state capital.

"Our brave firefighters were at the ICU, situated on the fifth floor of the hospital, within four minutes of the receipt of information, and they were able to evacuate 23 patients altogether. All the deaths have been caused by asphyxiation, and there were no burn injuries," Ahotkar said.

Fire officer R N Pandey, who had led the team that carried out the rescue operations, told reporters in Muzaffarpur that they received the information about the fire around 3 AM.

"But when we reached there, we found no flames but only dense, black smoke which was making it difficult to breathe and see things clearly," Pandey said.

Blaming hospital authorities for the loss of lives, Ahotkar said, "The staff who should have helped with evacuation chose to run away. And the hapless patients, most of whom were not able to move on their own, got trapped". AGENCIES

From Page 1

Venezuela

According to Tandon, Modi responded positively and expressed India's interest in building a deeper energy relationship covering exploration, production, refining and other segments of the petroleum value chain. The meeting took place against the backdrop of a sharp increase in India's purchases of Venezuelan crude oil. Since April, Venezuelan oil shipments to India have gained momentum, helping the South American nation emerge as the country's third-largest oil supplier. Indian refiners have significantly stepped up sourcing from Venezuela in recent weeks as geopolitical tensions in West Asia disrupted shipping routes and added uncertainty to global energy markets. Oil Minister Hardeep Singh Puri, who also met Rodríguez, described the energy relationship as "long-standing" and "complementary". In a post on X, he noted that Venezuela holds the world's largest proven oil reserves while India brings strong demand, advanced refining capacity and expertise in processing heavy crude.

"India has a long standing energy partnership with Venezuela since 2008 and shares unique complementarities with the country," Puri said, adding that Indian refiners were among Venezuela's key crude buyers during April and May 2026.

Puri said Indian companies already have investments in Venezuela and are looking at further opportunities in the upstream oil sector and broader energy cooperation. "Our technical team will visit Venezuela soon to further explore this potential," he said, describing the initiative as part of India's wider strategy to strengthen energy security through diversified imports.

India imports around 90 per cent of its crude oil requirements, making diversification of supply sources a major policy objective as the country seeks to reduce exposure to price volatility and geopolitical risks.

During the discussions, the Indian side also raised the issue of more than USD 500 million in dividends owed to ONGC Videsh Ltd. Tandon said the matter was brought up with the Venezuelan leadership and added, "It is our money. They are very sensitive to the issue."

Beyond oil, both sides explored possibilities for cooperation in mining and critical minerals. Tandon said Venezuela's resource base extends well beyond hydrocarbons and includes gold, diamonds and other minerals. Discussions touched on assessing the country's resource potential and identifying opportunities for collaboration in exploration and development.

The two leaders also reviewed broader economic ties, including trade, investment, healthcare, pharmaceuticals, automobiles and agriculture. Ministry of External Affairs spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said the talks covered the full spectrum of bilateral relations and explored new avenues of cooperation across multiple sectors. "The leaders also exchanged views on global and regional issues of mutual interest. Both sides reaffirmed their commitment to deepening the bilateral partnership and advancing the interests of the Global South," Jaiswal said.

Tandon said the issue of BRICS was also discussed, with Rodríguez complimenting India and Modi on New Delhi's leadership role in the grouping.

Rodríguez assumed the role of acting president after the detention of then Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro by US forces in January. While questions were raised about Venezuela's political transition, Tandon did not directly address whether the matter figured in the talks. He said India was working with a friendly government that wanted a stronger partnership with New Delhi and noted that Venezuela had traditionally been a close friend of India both bilaterally and in international forums. The Venezuelan leader is accompanied by a high-level delegation that includes ministers responsible for foreign affairs, economy and finance, science and technology, communication and information, and transportation. During the visit, the delegation is scheduled to tour facilities linked to India's energy, pharmaceutical and automobile sectors to better understand the country's industrial and technological capabilities. Rodríguez is also expected to visit Reliance Industries' refinery complex in Jamnagar, Gujarat, one of the world's largest refining hubs. "The Venezuelan leader will be exposed to the sophistication that India has achieved in the energy sector," Tandon said.

India and Venezuela have maintained close ties for decades, with former Venezuelan President Hugo Chávez's 2005 state visit to India providing a major boost to the relationship. Energy cooperation remains a cornerstone of the partnership. ONGC Videsh and Venezuela's Corporacion Venezolana del Petroleo jointly operate Petrolera Indovenezolana SA in the San Cristobal oil field, where the Indian company holds a 40 per cent stake.

India was once a major buyer of Venezuelan crude, importing more than 400,000 barrels per day at peak levels before US sanctions and compliance concerns halted purchases in 2020. Following the easing of restrictions and the resumption of trade, energy ties have regained momentum, with both countries now seeking to build a broader and more durable economic partnership.

Delhi hotel

Bed and Breakfast on Wednesday morning, killing 21 people, including 12 foreign nationals, and injuring at least 25 others. Many of those staying at the establishment were in Delhi to accompany relatives undergoing treatment at nearby hospitals. While the exact cause of the fire is yet to be determined, investigators are examining alleged fire-safety violations, building norm breaches and possible illegal construction at the property.

Teams from Delhi Police, the crime branch and forensic experts remained at the site on Thursday, combing through the gutted structure and questioning residents, shopkeepers, hotel staff and witnesses. The area around the hotel was sealed off as investigators attempted to reconstruct the sequence of events that led to the tragedy.

According to officials, the establishment had permission for only six rooms but was allegedly operating around 25 rooms, including some in the basement. Authorities are also verifying reports that additional floors were constructed without the required approvals.

Investigators are examining whether the building lacked mandatory fire-safety clearances. Officials said the property allegedly did not possess a fire no-objection certificate. They are also looking into claims that sealed windows, a single staircase, limited exit routes and a sensor-operated main door may have hindered evacuation efforts as the fire spread.

At least 58 people were rescued from the building, but 21 succumbed to burns and suffocation. Initial findings have raised questions about whether guests had sufficient means to escape once the fire intensified. The tragedy has left behind stories of immense personal loss. Among those killed were eight members of a family from Gurugram. Mahender Garg lost his cousin, chartered accountant Vivek Agarwal, along with seven other relatives, including Vivek's wife Tarjini, their two daughters, his mother and other family members. Standing outside a hospital mortuary on Thursday, Garg recalled speaking to Vivek shortly before the situation turned fatal.

"He called me about 10 minutes before the incident got worse. He was frantically saying, 'I am trapped in the basement. Please send the fire brigade quickly and get me out of here," Garg said.

The family had booked rooms at the hotel because Vivek's father, Radhe Shyam Agarwal, was undergoing treatment at a nearby hospital. "All eight are gone. My entire family has been destroyed. They came here hoping that my cousin's father would recover from his illness. Instead, we are taking back the bodies of our loved ones," Garg said.

Another relative said the family was struggling to comprehend how their lives had changed within hours. "My sister, my brother-in-law and my two nieces are gone. One of the girls had come from Bengaluru just two days ago. She was studying there in college and had come to see her grandfather," the relative said.

Outside the mortuary, family members questioned the safety arrangements at the hotel, alleging that the building's design left occupants with little opportunity to escape. As investigations continued, the atmosphere in Malviya Nagar remained sombre.

The narrow lane where the fire broke out, usually crowded with visitors, attendants and hotel guests, was marked by silence, police barricades and the lingering smell of smoke. The charred structure stood as a stark reminder of the disaster that unfolded less than 24 hours earlier. Residents continued to recount scenes of panic and desperation.

One local resident said he rushed to the spot after receiving a call from a tenant informing him about the fire.

"When I reached there, several people were trapped inside. They were hitting the glass windows with their hands and signalling for help. We gathered stones, hammers and other tools to break the glass. After creating an opening, we went upstairs and helped rescue the people who were trapped inside," he said. Mattresses used during rescue operations remained outside the building on Thursday. They had been placed below windows to cushion the fall of people who jumped from upper floors in desperate attempts to survive. For many residents, the memories remain difficult to shake off. A shopkeeper whose store is located near the hotel said he had been unable to sleep after witnessing the aftermath.

"Charred bodies and people jumping from the building, I couldn't sleep all night after seeing it. Even a small sound now scares me," he said. Another resident, Kanhaiya, said the screams of trapped guests continued to haunt the neighbourhood. "Whenever we pass through this street, these memories will come back. We can never forget those cries," he said. The impact of the tragedy extended beyond the hotel itself. Foreign nationals and other guests staying in nearby hotels and guest houses were seen packing their belongings and leaving the area on Thursday. Several establishments shut their doors following the incident, while others reportedly stopped food services and electricity supply.

Three establishments linked to the same owner, Flourish Stay, Florist Inn and Green Residency, remained closed. Jilbert, a guest from the Republic of Congo, said he was leaving because essential services had been disrupted.

"Since yesterday, there has been no food arrangement, and there is no electricity supply. We have been facing difficulties and are leaving. We will find another place to stay," he said. Bilunga Mukasa, another foreign national living in the area, said the incident had shaken residents and guests alike. "People are scared after the incident. Many guests are leaving, and some are looking for accommodation elsewhere because they do not feel safe staying here anymore," he said.

A woman from Uzbekistan who had come to Delhi for medical treatment said residents of her guest house were asked to vacate following the fire. Long-time residents said the locality had undergone significant changes over the past decade as guest houses and budget hotels multiplied to cater to people visiting nearby hospitals. Some residents alleged that many such establishments lacked adequate safety infrastructure and called for wider inspections.

Meanwhile, the Delhi government announced financial assistance for the victims and their families.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta visited injured survivors at Max Hospital in Saket and announced an ex gratia payment of Rs 10 lakh to the next of kin of each deceased victim. Those seriously injured will receive Rs 5 lakh. According to officials, Gupta reviewed treatment arrangements and directed authorities to ensure that all injured persons receive the best possible medical care. She also instructed officials to coordinate matters involving foreign nationals and facilitate the transportation of mortal remains to victims' hometowns. The victims included citizens of India as well as Bangladesh, Nepal, Cameroon and Libya.

BJP MLA Satish Upadhyay, who accompanied the chief minister, said 17 injured people were admitted to Max Hospital, including seven on ventilator support. He said the condition of patients had improved over the previous 24 hours.

ATF stabilisation

following the outbreak of conflict in West Asia.

Airlines that choose not to join the scheme will continue to pay prevailing international prices, which are currently around Rs 142 per litre. By comparison, ATF is presently being supplied in Delhi at about Rs 105 per litre under a capped pricing mechanism introduced in April.

The government had then allowed only a partial pass-through of rising fuel costs, raising prices by 25 per cent instead of the full increase. Since then, state-owned oil marketing companies (OMCs) have continued supplying fuel at capped rates while absorbing losses.

International jet fuel prices climbed sharply from about Rs 60.50 per litre to as much as Rs 142 per litre in May, raising concerns over airline finances and the possibility of higher airfares.

To support the new mechanism, the government will provide an interest-free advance of up to Rs 10,000 crore to OMCs. The funds will compensate retailers for the difference whenever international fuel prices exceed the benchmark level and fuel is supplied to participating airlines at the fixed rate.

Raj described the arrangement as a temporary and self-correcting mechanism rather than a subsidy.

"Under the scheme, the government will provide an interest-free advance to all marketing companies, enabling them to supply ATF to participating Indian airlines at a predetermined and stable price for both domestic and international operations whenever international ATF prices rise above the benchmark level," he said. He added that any compensation paid to OMCs during periods of elevated fuel prices would be recovered once global prices decline. The recovered amount would then be returned to the Consolidated Fund of India through a prescribed and transparent mechanism.

"Thus, the arrangement is intended not as a subsidy but a temporary stabilisation method to smoothen the impact of exceptional fuel price volatility while ensuring full accountability, monitoring, and recovery of funds," Raj said.

The scheme will remain operational for up to 36 months or until the entire government advance has been recovered, whichever comes first. Officials said the decision was taken to safeguard air connectivity and maintain stability in aviation services during a period of extraordinary volatility in global fuel markets. They noted that ATF accounts for roughly 40 per cent of airline operating costs and can rise to nearly 60 per cent during periods of extreme price fluctuations.

The burden on Indian carriers has also increased because of longer flight routes necessitated by the closure of Pakistan's airspace.

The ministry said the fixed-price arrangement would provide airlines with greater certainty in planning operations across domestic and international networks. For passengers, the government expects the measure to reduce the likelihood of sudden fare increases by limiting the impact of sharp fuel price spikes on airline costs. According to government officials, after adding airport charges, oil company margins and applicable taxes, the effective ATF selling price will be about Rs 115 per litre in Delhi, Rs 114.5 per litre in Mumbai and around Rs 139 per litre in Chennai. Participation in the scheme will be voluntary.

Briefing reporters, Rohit Raj, Director in the Ministry of Civil Aviation, said the new arrangement would replace the temporary fuel price capping system introduced earlier this year after international ATF prices surged.

IMD issues

temperature drops, with Ayanagar witnessing the steepest fall of 19 degrees Celsius. Mayur Vihar recorded a decline of 14.9 degrees Celsius, followed by Pushp Vihar at 14.8 degrees, Sports Complex at 14.6 degrees, Mungeshpur at 14.4 degrees and Pitampura at 14 degrees.

Pragati Maidan and Jharoda Kalan each registered a drop of 12.2 degrees Celsius, while temperatures at Palam fell by 12 degrees.

Rainfall was also significant in several pockets of the city. Ayanagar recorded the highest rainfall between 8.30 am and 5.30 pm at 27.8 mm, followed by Mayur Vihar with 23 mm. The Ridge received 19 mm, while Pragati Maidan logged 12.8 mm. Palam recorded 10.7 mm of rain, Pushp Vihar 10.5 mm, Pusa 8 mm, Lodhi Road 4 mm and Safdarjung 1.6 mm. Strong winds accompanied the storm activity. The highest wind speed of 65 kmph was recorded at Palam. Pitampura reported winds of 56 kmph, while Pragati Maidan saw gusts of 52 kmph and Pusa recorded 50 kmph. Wind speeds at Safdarjung reached 36 kmph.

The IMD said Delhi is likely to witness a partly cloudy sky turning generally cloudy, with light rain, thunderstorms, lightning and winds of 40-50 kmph, gusting up to 60 kmph. Another spell of light rain and thunderstorms is expected during the night.

Safdarjung, the city's base weather station, recorded a maximum temperature of 40.5 degrees Celsius and a minimum of 29.7 degrees Celsius. Temperatures remained close to normal seasonal levels despite the storm activity.

Mahesh Palawat, vice-president of Skymet Weather, said, "There is a fresh western disturbance and cyclonic circulation over central Pakistan, Haryana and northwest Rajasthan, as a result of which rain and thunderstorm activity is expected over the region for the next three days." For Friday, the IMD has forecast generally cloudy skies with more spells of rain and thunderstorms. The maximum temperature is expected to remain between 39 and 41 degrees Celsius, while the minimum temperature is likely to range from 25 to 27 degrees Celsius. Delhi's 24-hour average Air Quality Index stood at 164, placing it in the "moderate" category, according to the Central Pollution Control Board.

Southwest monsoon

further advanced into the remaining parts of southwest and southeast Arabian Sea, some parts of westcentral and eastcentral Arabian Sea, entire Lakshadweep islands, Kerala and Mahe, some parts of Karnataka and Tamil Nadu, remaining parts of Comorin area, southeast Bay of Bengal and some more parts of southwest, westcentral, eastcentral and northeast Bay of Bengal today the 4th June, 2026," the IMD said.

Previously, the weather department had predicted that the monsoon would begin over Kerala on May 26; however, the arrival was delayed. Last week, the department revised its forecast for seasonal rainfall, indicating that it would be below normal.

The IMD expects rainfall in India to be around 90% of the long-period average (LPA) this year.

The LPA refers to the rainfall recorded in a specific region over a defined period, such as a month or season, averaged over a long duration, typically 30 to 50 years.

The long-period average (LPA) of seasonal rainfall over the country as a whole, based on data from 1971 to 2020, is 87 cm. If the monsoon season sees less than 90 pc of LPA rainfall, the IMD classifies it as 'deficient'. One reason behind the below-normal rainfall could be the emergence of El Nino conditions, which lead to less rain during the monsoon in the country.

Currently, neutral El Nino-Southern Oscillation conditions are transitioning towards El Nino conditions over the equatorial Pacific region. The IMD said that El Nino conditions are likely to be weak in June, and moderate to strong in September. MPOST

DMK to boycott

participates," the party said.

The development follows TVK chief and Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay's announcement that his party would support the Congress for the lone Rajya Sabha seat from the state that fell vacant after AIADMK leader C. Ve. Shanmugam resigned from the Upper House. Shanmugam stepped down after winning the Mailam Assembly constituency in the April 23 state election.

Vijay said the seat had been allocated to the Congress, a partner in the TVK-led alliance in Tamil Nadu, ahead of the Rajya Sabha election scheduled for June 18. The decision came after meetings involving senior Congress leaders, including former Union Finance Minister P. Chidambaram and the party's Tamil Nadu in-charge Girish Chodankar.

After meeting Vijay at the Secretariat, Chodankar said the Congress would strengthen its presence in the Rajya Sabha through the Tamil Nadu seat. With TVK holding the largest strength in the Assembly, the Congress nominee is expected to secure an easy victory.

According to Election Commission sources, nominations will be accepted until June 8, scrutiny will take place on June 9, withdrawals can be made until June 11, and voting and counting will be held on June 18.

Delimitation Bills

Sabha elections. The move could pave the way for the first major redrawing of parliamentary constituencies in decades and reopen a debate that has long divided India's political landscape.

The outreach also comes at a crucial juncture. The current allocation of Lok Sabha seats is based on population figures frozen after the 1971 Census. While the Lok Sabha currently has 543 elected members, any delimitation exercise after the constitutional freeze ends is expected to alter the balance of representation among states. The Centre is conscious of concerns raised by states that have successfully controlled population growth and is working towards a formula that can secure wider political acceptance, government sources said.

According to sources, the government's assessment is that a consensus-driven approach will be critical to avoid turning delimitation into a politically divisive issue, so discussions are focused on addressing concerns while preserving the principle of fair representation.

BJP, Congress

Four candidates, Rajubhai Shukla, Mukeshbhai Rathwa, Mansingh Parmar and Jitendra Meghjibhai Kanzariya, were named from Gujarat.

The announcement drew attention because the names of Union ministers Ravneet Singh Bittu and George Kurian were missing from the BJP's list. Their current Rajya Sabha terms are scheduled to end on June 21. Bittu represents Rajasthan in the Upper House, while Kurian is a member from Madhya Pradesh.

Kurian is considered the only Christian minister in the present Union government. The decision not to renominate him and Bittu, coupled with the recent appointment of Harsh Malhotra as Delhi BJP president, has fuelled speculation in political circles about a possible Cabinet reshuffle in the coming months. Another Union minister, Hardeep Singh Puri, is also due to complete his Rajya Sabha tenure in November.

Chugh, a BJP national general secretary, hails from Punjab and currently oversees the party's affairs in Jammu and Kashmir. Poonia, a former Rajasthan BJP president and the party's Haryana in-charge, was defeated in the 2023 Rajasthan Assembly election.

Samantaray's nomination marks a notable political shift. The former Rajya Sabha member from Odisha recently joined the BJP after quitting the Biju Janata Dal (BJD) and resigning from the Upper House.

On the Congress side, the party announced seven candidates for the Rajya Sabha elections, including party president Mallikarjun Kharge from Karnataka and media department chairman Pawan Khera.

The Congress also nominated AICC secretary for Kerala and Lakshadweep Mansoor Ali Khan from Karnataka. Khan had contested the 2024 Lok Sabha election from Bengaluru Central but was unsuccessful.

Senior Congress leader Meenakshi Natarajan was chosen as the party's candidate from Madhya Pradesh. A former Lok Sabha MP from Mandsaur and currently the party's Telangana in-charge, Natarajan is set to contest for the seat being vacated by former Madhya Pradesh chief minister Digvijaya Singh.

The party named Praveen Chakravarty, head of its Data Analytics and Professionals Wing, as its candidate from Tamil Nadu. The seat became available following the resignation of AIADMK leader C. Ve. Shanmugam, who was elected to the Tamil Nadu Assembly.

Congress also renominated Neeraj Dangi from Rajasthan and fielded Pranav Jha from Jharkhand. Jha is currently attached to the office of the Congress president and will contest one of the two Rajya Sabha seats from the state.

In a statement, AICC general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal said Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge had approved the party's candidates for the biennial and by-elections to the Council of States.

Following the announcement, several candidates expressed gratitude to the party leadership. Mansoor Ali Khan said on social media platform X that he accepted the responsibility with humility and would work to uphold parliamentary standards while representing the voices of people who often remain unheard.

The Rajya Sabha elections for 24 seats across 10 states, including Gujarat, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Manipur and Arunachal Pradesh, will be held on June 18. By-elections for one seat each in Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu and Odisha will also take place on the same day. June 8 is the last date for filing nominations.

KARNATAKA CM PROMISES 'FREE, FAIR GOVERNMENT'

Day after assuming charge, Shivakumar rolls out grievance redressal set-up

OUR CORRESPONDENT


CM DK Shivakumar greets the police personnel during a high-level review meeting on Thursday PTI

Highlights

- » Stating that the new government had begun its work, Shivakumar said officials had been informed about the government's priorities and direction
- » "We told them what is expected of them, and they, in turn, told us what they expect from us," he said
- » The CM said his government would not tolerate influence based on caste or religion, and asked officials not to yield to pressure

BENGALURU: Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Thursday said that his government would set up a separate secretariat to address public grievances.

He also asked officials to prepare action plans for their respective departments within fifteen days. He directed them not to succumb to pressure and to work with integrity, conscience, and a positive approach. A day after assuming office, the CM held a meeting with top bureaucrats and police officials in the state, during which he stressed providing a "free, fair, and corruption-free" government.

"A separate secretariat will be established to address public grievances, and a minister will be appointed to listen to people coming to Bengaluru from across the state with complaints, demands, or issues, including those staging protests or agitations. There is a need for such a separate secretariat," Shivakumar told reporters after the meeting.

He added: "Every day, two or three groups come here to protest. Someone has to meet them and understand their problems. It is important to determine whether their demands are legal or illegal. Officials must meet them, hear the facts, and understand their issues. Therefore, a decision has been made to establish a separate secretariat."

Deputy Chief Minister G Parameshwara, Minister Ramalinga Reddy, Chief Secretary Shalini Rajneesh, Director General of Police M A Saleem, and other senior officials were present.

Stating that the new government had begun its work, Shivakumar said officials had been informed about the government's priorities and direction. "We told them what is expected of them, and they, in turn, told us what they expect from us," he said.

The CM said his government would not tolerate influence based on caste or religion, and asked officials not to yield to pressure. "Officials must respond transparently to the feelings and concerns of the people. They have been instructed to work with a positive approach," he said.

Shivakumar also said officials had been asked to prepare action plans for their respective departments within fifteen days. "Everything must be accountable. There should be basic common sense, and every problem has a solution. There must be a positive attitude and approach. I conveyed this to the officials," he added.

"I do not like reading or writing history; I prefer creating history. We must leave behind evidence of our work. Whenever we have had an opportunity, we have done so. This government will work in the same direction," he said.

PM to launch 'ease of living' projects in Gujarat, Daman

Will unveil projects worth Rs 22,000 crore

OUR CORRESPONDENT


PM Narendra Modi delivers video message during the virtual inauguration of 1st World Yogasana Sports Championship PTI

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi will visit Gujarat and Daman on Friday and inaugurate and lay the foundation stone of various development projects worth around Rs 22,000 crore.

The prime minister will also address a gathering in Surat.

The projects which will be inaugurated include a 200-bed ESIC Hospital in Surat and a new terminal building of NAMO Airport in Daman.

"I will be in Surat, Gujarat and Daman tomorrow, 5th June, to attend various programmes aimed at improving 'Ease of Living' for the people. In these two programmes, development works worth over Rs 20,000 crore will be inaugurated or their foundation stones will be laid," Modi said in a post on 'X'.

The prime minister said in Daman, the key inaugurations include a new terminal building of the airport, which will improve connectivity.

"The Namo hospital will cater to people's healthcare needs. The foundation stones for projects like the Daman Convention Centre and the NIFT Campus will be laid," he said.

According to an official statement, the prime minister will visit Hazira in Surat district on June 5 and review ongoing industrial operations and infrastructure projects.

Later, he will launch various development projects worth around Rs 18,800 crore in Surat and address a gathering on the occasion.

The prime minister will also inaugurate Packages VI and VII of the Vadodara-Mumbai Expressway, which aims to enhance high-speed transportation, logistics efficiency and economic connectivity between Gujarat and Maharashtra.

Modi will then inaugurate the 200-bed ESIC Hospital in Surat.

He will then travel to Daman, where he will inaugurate a new terminal building of the NAMO Airport and a healthcare facility -- the Namo Hospital.

The PM will also lay the foundation stone of projects with the aim to strengthen modern infrastructure, boost tourism, promote investment, generate employment opportunities and improve the quality of life of the people, the statement said.

CJP attacks government on JEE data exposure, calls for Pradhan's sacking

NEW DELHI: The Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) on Thursday said the reported exposure of JEE (Advanced) 2026 candidate data due to a cloud storage configuration issue in the results portal showed how "incompetent" people were running the country's education system and digital infrastructure.

The leaders of the campaign, which began on social media and went on to take a life of its own, also appealed to Prime Minister Narendra Modi to immediately sack Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, saying he had failed to ensure accountability in the education sector.

Addressing a press conference here, CJP leaders said the incident had raised fresh concerns about the security of student data and the government's handling of examination systems.

> 'Names, phone numbers and images of nearly two lakh students got exposed'

CJP spokesperson Ashutosh Ranka, an alumnus of IIT Kanpur and the London School of Economics who was appointed the campaign's spokesperson on Wednesday, said the exposure of candidate information reflected the poor state of cybersecurity safeguards.

"Names, phone numbers and images of nearly two lakh students got exposed. In a country that has produced techies leading top technology companies across the world, the education minister and the government are so incompetent that they are unable to run basic systems securely," Ranka said.

"The education minister is totally incompetent. He has run the education system into the ground. We appeal to the PM to sack Dharmendra Pradhan immediately," he added.

He also said public institutions required individuals with scientific temper and technical competence. MPOST

Rahul accuses Modi of serving 'external interests'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

DEHRADUN: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Thursday accused Prime Minister Narendra Modi of working to further external interests, claiming that the central government was "systematically dismantling" critical socio-economic protections.

Addressing a public rally in Uttarakhand's Almora via phone, Rahul accused the central government of being involved in the 'looting' of the state's natural resources.

"The team of Narendra Modi and Amit Shah has destroyed the economic foundation established by the Congress party, which was aimed at empowering the common man. Demonetisation has taken away the money you kept at home for emergencies, and the GST has harmed small businesses across the country," Rahul stated.

Rahul postponed his scheduled visit to Almora and returned to the Pantnagar airport midway after his helicopter encountered severe weather conditions.

The Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha later addressed the public rally, titled 'Parivartan ka Shankhnaad', over a phone call facilitated by Congress general secretary and Uttarakhand in-charge Kumari Selja.

Though a major portion of Gandhi's address over the phone was not clearly audible, he apologised to the people gathered in Almora for his inability to reach the venue and promised that he would visit them again soon.

"I was scheduled to arrive this morning. However, while we were travelling by the helicopter, the pilot informed us that the weather had deteriorated and we would have to return to Pantnagar," Gandhi said.

Addressing the public, the Congress leader alleged that the vision behind the creation of Uttarakhand was being undermined.

'Rahul working against India's stability'

NEW DELHI: The BJP on Thursday hit back at Congress leader Rahul Gandhi over his claim that Prime Minister Narendra Modi will no longer remain in office in a year's time, accusing him of spreading propaganda to create "instability" in the country. Calling Gandhi a "certified anarchist", the ruling party also noted that the only Emergency imposed in the country was by former prime minister Indira Gandhi. Referring to Gandhi's remarks that India is heading towards an "economic tsunami", Malviya said it is a classic case of "fear-mongering". "If India's shock absorbers had truly been removed, why is the economy continuing to show resilience despite elevated crude prices, conflict in West Asia, supply-chain disruptions, global financial tightening and persistent geopolitical uncertainty?", he said. AGENCIES

Akhilesh slams BJP over water woes in Chitrakoot

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Samajwadi Party president and former Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Akhilesh Yadav on Thursday attacked the BJP government over the reported water crisis in Chitrakoot, alleging that the ruling party's claims of development had collapsed in the face of public suffering.

In a statement, Yadav said the plight of elderly people, women and children struggling for drinking water in Chitrakoot had exposed what he described as the failure of the BJP government's development agenda.

"The public is asking for water today and wondering what use promises of a developed India by 2047 are when basic necessities remain unavailable," he said.

Yadav alleged that as long as the BJP remained in power, schemes such as the Jal Jeevan Mission would continue to fail. Referring to incidents of water tanks collapsing in different parts of the state, he said the government's promise of providing tap water to every household existed only on paper.

The SP chief also accused the BJP government of corruption and mismanagement, claiming that public funds meant for development projects were being siphoned off through commissions.

He alleged that this was the reason behind the collapse of water tanks, damaged roads and incidents involving bridges.

"The BJP government has failed in every sector. Development funds are being looted, while infrastructure projects are suffering because of corruption," Yadav said.

He further accused the government of failing to clean rivers despite allocating substantial funds for the purpose.

According to Yadav, rivers across the state remain polluted and many have dried up, while untreated sewage from cities continues to flow into them.

SC upholds HC order on Vinesh trials row

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday dismissed a plea by the Wrestling Federation of India against a Delhi High Court order allowing wrestler Vinesh Phogat to participate in selection trials, terming it as infructuous in view of subsequent developments.

A bench of Justices PS Narasimha and Aravind Kumar, which refused to go into the observations made by the high court, said this court should not be taken as having reiterated the findings and observations made in the order.

Without directing the expunging of "objectionable" observations in the high court order, the bench said all the issues are left open and dismissed the WFI's plea

Senior advocate DN Goburdhun, appearing for the WFI, said Phogat was allowed to participate in the selection trials but she did not succeed.

"She did not succeed but she created havoc over there," the senior counsel told the bench.

The bench told him that the issue had become infructuous.

Goburdhun submitted that there were certain observations made by the high court with regard to decisions of the federation and terming them "mala fide" and "deplorable". "All these observations will have to go as the matter is pending before the single bench," the senior counsel submitted. The top court then left the questions open and disposed of the plea while terming it as infructuous. AGENCIES

Bengal Assembly integrates with national e-Vidhan platform

OUR CORRESPONDENT

e-Vidhan

- » CM Adhikari reaffirmed the state government's commitment to modernising governance institutions through technology
- » Rijiju said the application had been launched to realise PM Modi's vision of 'One Nation, One Application'

KOLKATA: The Union Ministry of Parliamentary Affairs and the West Bengal Legislative Assembly on Thursday signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) for the implementation of the National e-Vidhan Application (NeVA) in the state Assembly. Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari, who joined the MoU signing ceremony via video conferencing, welcomed the initiative and reaffirmed the state government's commitment to modernising governance institutions through technology.

West Bengal Legislative Assembly Speaker Rathindra Bose expressed confidence that the implementation of NeVA would enhance the efficiency, transparency and accessibility of legislative functioning in the state.

Union Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju, who attended the programme from New Delhi, described the integration of the West Bengal Assembly into NeVA as a historic step. He said that all state assemblies and Parliament are now connected through a common digital platform.

Rijiju said the application had been launched to realise Prime Minister Narendra Modi's vision of "One Nation, One Application". He highlighted the importance of digital transformation in legislative institutions and reiterated the Centre's commitment to supporting the West Bengal Assembly in its transition towards becoming a fully digital House. Union MoS Arjun Ram Meghwal and Speaker Rathindra Bose also attended the ceremony.

Nihangs hit back at HP with 'Khalsa tax'

ASHWANI SHARMA

SHIMLA: Unusual tension has resurfaced along the Punjab-Himachal Pradesh border over the hill state's decision to impose an entry tax to shore up revenues amid a fiscal crisis and the Centre's move to stop its Revenue Deficit Grant (RDG).

The Congress government led by Sukhwinder Singh Sukhu has defended the levy, calling it a compulsion necessitated by the state's financial difficulties.

Even before the Punjab government could officially impose a reciprocal tax on vehicles entering from Himachal Pradesh, lathi-wielding Nihangs gathered at the interstate border and blocked the Kiratpur Sahib–Manali National Highway, a key route connecting the two states.

The blockade lasted for more than four hours.

Protesters described it as the first phase of an agitation aimed at forcing the Himachal Pradesh government to withdraw the levy and allow free entry for vehicles from Punjab, particularly those carrying tourists and Sikh devotees. They claimed to be part of a coordinated protest announced earlier by a Sangharsh Committee at 56 entry and exit points linking Himachal Pradesh with neighbouring states.

> Claim to be part of a coordinated protest announced by a Sangharsh Committee

Long queues of vehicles formed on both sides of the highway as commuters, tourists and transporters faced major delays. Traffic remained suspended for hours, leaving many stranded on the route. The blockade disrupted travel to tourist destinations such as Manali, Bilaspur and Kullu, while also affecting the movement of commercial vehicles transporting goods between the two states.

Nihang leader Achhar Singh, who led the protest, said the Himachal Pradesh government's decision had caused harassment and inconvenience to hundreds of travellers and vehicle owners.

The protesters termed the levy an unjustified financial burden on travellers, transporters and businesses from neighbouring states. They argued that the tax affects not only tourists but also farmers, traders, transport operators and residents of border areas who depend on regular interstate movement for business and livelihood.

SC unveils draft AI rules for courts

Public and stakeholder feedback invited on Apex Court's draft AI framework

Key Points

- » Inviting comments and suggestions from stakeholders and the general public by June 20, the Artificial Intelligence Committee of the Supreme Court provides for allowing AI tools in "case management (including identification of defects in new filings), cause list preparation, hearing scheduling and docket prioritisation"
- » The draft regulations expressly permit AI to be used for a range of judicial and administrative functions, subject to approval and human supervision.

- » Among other things, AI may be used for Legal research and precedent retrieval, citation verification, summarising pleadings, judgments and documents, and translation of judgments, orders and legal documents.

NEW DELHI: In a move to modernise the legal landscape while safeguarding judicial integrity, the Supreme Court released draft 'Regulations for Use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) in courts' which contain a list of permissible and forbidden usage, stating that "no judicial outcome shall be reached through Algorithmic Decision-Making alone."

Inviting comments and suggestions from stakeholders and the general public by June 20, the Artificial Intelligence Committee of the Supreme Court provides for allowing AI tools in "case management (including identification of defects in new filings), cause list preparation, hearing scheduling and docket prioritisation".

The draft regulations for use of AI in courts "shall apply to the use, deployment, or integration of AI in any judicial, adjudicatory or administrative function of the Supreme Court of India, High Courts, and all Courts including the Tribunals and statutory Commissions performing adjudicatory functions, within the territory of India".

The necessity for such a regulatory framework has become increasingly evident as the top court and several High Courts have raised concerns about the misuse of AI tools, which sometimes produce non-existent case laws that have even influenced actual judgments.

At the same time, the justices of the Supreme Court have emphasised the importance of using AI tools to enhance benefits such as translating judgments into local languages and streamlining legal searches.

"These regulations aim to govern the use of AI, grounded in the principles of human primacy, transparency, accountability, data protection, and judicial independence, while establishing an institutional framework for responsible AI adoption across India's judicial system," the Apex court said in its notice.

The 35-page draft proposes a clear "red line" for technology, indicating that while AI may assist, it will never replace the human mind.

According to one of the regulations, "the use of AI in court processes shall at all times remain strictly subservient to human judgment and judicial authority and every AI System shall function solely in an assistive capacity and shall not supplant or compromise the independent exercise of judicial authority by a duly appointed judicial officer and the ultimate authority to determine matters of law, fact and justice shall vest exclusively in the judicial officers of the competent jurisdiction."

Regulation 20 states that the use of AI for reaching judicial outcomes, such as judgments, sentencing, or determining the credibility of witnesses, is strictly forbidden.

All adjudicatory functions must involve a "Human-in-the-Loop" (HITL) approach, ensuring that final decision-making authority remains solely with a duly appointed judicial officer.

"No judicial outcome (including any judgment, order, or finding of fact or law) shall be reached through Algorithmic Decision-Making alone or solely on the basis of AI-generated information, data, or analysis and the human judicial authority shall be the determinative authority in all adjudicative decisions," it said.

The draft outlined a strategic roadmap for adopting AI to tackle the judiciary's massive caseload.

It said that courts will be encouraged to use AI for case management, automated transcription of proceedings, translation of legal documents into regional languages, legal research assistance, and guided chatbots to help litigants navigate court procedures. AGENCIES

73RD NEC PLENARY MEETING

Home Min Amit Shah outlines roadmap for N-E's transformation

NARESH BISWANI

SHILLONG: Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday outlined an ambitious roadmap for transforming the Northeast into a major centre for trade, investment, innovation and sustainable development while chairing the 73rd Plenary Meeting of the North Eastern Council in Shillong.

Addressing representatives of the Northeastern states, Shah said the region has undergone a significant transformation since Prime Minister Narendra Modi assumed office. He highlighted the signing of more than a dozen peace accords, improved law and order, and major advancements in road, rail and air connectivity that have helped integrate the region more closely with the rest of the country.

Emphasising the Centre's commitment to the Northeast, Shah said the vision of "Purvodaya" has evolved through the government's "Act East" policy and has been strengthened through initiatives aimed at accelerating development across the region. He noted that sustained efforts have created new opportunities for economic growth while preserving peace and stability.

The Home minister urged all Northeastern states to implement the recommendations of the High-Level Task Force to ensure that development progresses without compromising the region's rich cultural heritage and unique identity. To boost investment, Shah called upon state governments to regularly review the effectiveness of the Single Window Clearance System and make it more investor-friendly.

Union Home minister Amit Shah during the NEC Plenary Meeting in Shillong. Union minister Jyotiraditya Scindia, along with Meghalaya Governor C.H. Vijayashankar and CM Conrad Sangma are also seen

HIGHLIGHTS

- Shah said the region has undergone a significant transformation since Prime Minister Narendra Modi assumed office
- He noted that sustained efforts have created new opportunities for economic growth while preserving peace and stability
- He urged Northeastern states to implement the recommendations of the High-Level Task Force to ensure that development progresses without compromising the region's rich cultural heritage and unique identity
- To boost investment, Shah called upon state governments to regularly review the effectiveness of the Single Window Clearance System and make it more investor-friendly

He also highlighted the strategic importance of the Sabroom land port in Tripura and newly established customs facilities in Meghalaya and Mizoram, saying these would strengthen trade connectivity with South-east Asia and the wider Indo-Pacific region.

Shah stressed the need to develop a focused export strategy for products in which the Northeast enjoys a natural advantage, including agarwood, essential oils, wellness products, cosmetics and bamboo-based industries. He also encouraged states to promote GI-tagged products, expand organic farming and strengthen tourism through the "One District, One Tourist Destination" initiative.

Highlighting the importance of technology-driven growth, Shah said the Northeast has the potential to emerge as a hub for emerging sectors such as artificial intelligence and data analytics. He emphasised the need for greater investment in education, skill development and digital infrastructure to prepare the region for future opportunities.

The plenary session was attended by CMs, Governors, senior officials of the Northeastern states and representatives of the Centre, who discussed strategies to accelerate the region's development.

EFFORTS TO BOOST OPERATIONAL EFFICIENCY

Rajnath approves two-fold increase in financial ceiling for field commanders

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Defence minister Rajnath Singh on Thursday approved a two-fold increase in financial powers for field commanders to strengthen operational efficiency and ensure faster conclusion of contracts as well as execution of projects.

Special financial powers delegated to the commanders of the Indian Army, Air Force and Indian Navy have been increased significantly, along with a 100 per cent increase in the total ceiling provided to meet urgent operational requirements, the Defence ministry said.

In addition to the enhancement in financial powers, new provisions have been included to promote joint service procurement by the lead service with higher delegation than the normal procurement, it said. "Many new Competent Financial Authorities have been introduced to decentralise the procurement of goods and services."

Defence minister Rajnath Singh releases a revised manual for 'Delegation of Financial Powers for the Defence Services' in New Delhi PTI

Singh released a revised manual for 'Delegation of Financial Powers for the Defence Services' at an event in New Delhi. "The enhancement in the financial powers has been made up to 100 per cent, and even more than double in some cases. This would further strengthen the operational efficiency of field commanders, and lead to faster conclusion of contracts and execution of projects," the ministry said.

It said the financial powers delegated for indigenisation and research and development within the military ecosystem have been doubled to boost 'Aatmanirbharta' (self-reliance) in defence by minimising the dependency on foreign original equipment manufacturers.

The revised delegation of financial powers will facilitate procurement of more than Rs 1.25 lakh crore through the revenue route, as per current year budgetary allocations, the ministry said. Financial powers were last notified in 2021. The revision was necessitated due to the expansion in force level and to cater to the increased expenditure on operations and sustenance vis-a-vis the increase in budgetary allocation, it said.

This revised delegation in financial powers, along with the revised Defence Procurement Manual, will give a fillip to procurement with expeditious decision making, it noted.

Chief of Defence Staff Gen N S Raja Subramani, Army Chief Gen Upendra Dwivedi, Navy Chief Admiral Krishna Swaminathan and Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh were present at the event.

BMC: 6-day high-tide spell to hit Mumbai from June 14

MPOST BUREAU

MUMBAI: Mumbai will experience 24 high tides exceeding 4.5 metres during the 2026 monsoon season, including a six-day spell from June 14 to 19, the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) said on Thursday.

According to the civic body, there will be six such high-tide periods each in June and July, five in August and seven in September. The first spell is expected between June 14 and 19, with wave heights ranging from 4.64 metres to 4.87 metres.

The season's highest tide is forecast on July 16, when waves are expected to reach 4.89 metres. The BMC has advised citizens to avoid beaches and seashore areas during high tides and follow official safety advisories.

JEE aspirant found hanging at Kota PG

MPOST BUREAU

KOTA: A 17-year-old JEE aspirant from Uttar Pradesh was found hanging in his hostel room in Kota's Rajiv Gandhi Nagar area, with police suspecting suicide. No suicide note was recovered, and the reason behind the incident is yet to be ascertained.

The deceased, identified as Aryan Ojha of Sant Kabir Nagar, had been preparing for the Joint Entrance Examination (JEE) at a coaching institute in Kota for nearly a year. He was staying in a hostel under the Jawahar Nagar police station limits.

According to police, Aryan did not attend classes on Wednesday and failed to respond to calls from fellow students. When repeated knocks on his room went unanswered, hostel residents broke open the door around 10.45 pm and found him hanging.

As hostel ceiling fans are fitted with anti-hanging devices, the teenager allegedly used a noose tied to an iron angle on the wall. He was rushed to a hospital, where doctors declared him dead.

This is the sixth reported case of a student suicide in Kota this year. Police said the family has not indicated any reason for the incident or levelled any allegations.

As per Supreme Court directions in regard to such cases, the police has registered a case under relevant sections and an investigation is underway, they added.

Census Phase-I: Punjab CS calls for timely completion of operations

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Secretary K A P Sinha on Thursday directed all district administrations and urban local bodies to ensure 100 per cent completion of Phase-I of Census 2027 — Houselisting and Housing Census Operations — before the second week of June, stressing that no extension would be granted beyond the notified schedule.

The directions were issued during a meeting of the State Level Census Coordination Committee (SLCCC), which reviewed the progress of Census 2027 Phase-I activities across the state. The meeting was attended by State Nodal Officer for Census Ghanshyam Thori, senior officials from key departments, and Principal Census Officers, including Deputy Commissioners and Municipal Commissioners, through video conferencing. Reviewing the progress of houselisting operations, creation of Houselisting Blocks (HLBs) and data quality measures, Sinha underscored the importance of timely and accurate census work for evidence-based planning and policymaking.

Director Census Operations, Punjab, Navjot Khosa informed the committee that work on 52,365 Houselisting Blocks is currently underway across the state. He said districts such as Barnala, Fazilka, Malerkotla, Moga and Shaheed Bhagat Singh Nagar, along with Municipal Corporations of Barnala, Abohar, Moga, Hoshiarpur and Batala, had shown commendable performance through effective field mobilisation and monitoring.

While expressing satisfaction over the overall progress, the Chief Secretary noted that a few districts and urban local bodies were lagging behind prescribed timelines. He directed the authorities to intensify field operations and ensure completion of all Houselisting Blocks within the stipulated period.

Sinha also instructed Principal Census Officers to conduct regular reviews and surprise field inspections to verify the accuracy and completeness of data collection. MPOST

Mizoram: ED targets Burmese 'supari' racket

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHAMPHAI: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has conducted extensive searches at nine locations in Champhai, a major border town along the India-Myanmar frontier in Mizoram, as part of an investigation into a large-scale illegal Burmese supari (dry areca nut) smuggling and money laundering racket.

According to official sources, the searches on Monday targeted a well-organised cross-border network suspected of illegally bringing Burmese areca nuts into India through unauthorised routes. Raids were carried out at the residences and business establishments of several individuals believed to be key facilitators of the smuggling operation.

Investigators are examining financial transactions, trade records and other documents to trace the movement of funds generated through the alleged illegal trade. Preliminary findings suggest that the network smuggled areca nuts across the India-Myanmar border through the Tiau River and stored the consignments at various locations before distributing them to markets in different parts of the country. Sources said the ED suspects that forged documents and manipulated electronic transit permits were used to disguise the smuggled areca nuts as legally sourced domestic produce. The agency is also probing allegations that certain individuals misused import records and customs clearances to facilitate the movement of consignments that had originally entered the country through illegal channels.

The proceeds generated from the alleged smuggling network, estimated to run into hundreds of crores of rupees, are believed to have been laundered through multiple financial transactions designed to conceal the origin of the funds.

Officials suspect that some persons may have exploited their recognised tribal status to obtain customs clearances and legitimise consignments linked to the illegal trade.

Upload 5-year roadmaps on AI tool, Haryana CM asks all depts

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini has directed all government departments to upload their five-year roadmaps and action plans under the 'Haryana Vision-2047' initiative on a specially developed AI platform to enable comprehensive monitoring and review of implementation.

Chairing a review meeting on the five-year roadmap of the Haryana Police Housing Corporation (HPHC), Saini said all departments must align their plans with the vision of a developed India and adopt global best practices. He instructed departments to submit annual action plans along with detailed quarterly timelines and said progress would be reviewed every quarter, with compliance to previous directions closely monitored. The CM also asked the HPHC to prepare a comprehensive plan for constructing adequate, high-quality housing for police personnel across the state. According to HPHC Managing Director Alok Mittal, the corporation has built 12,683 residential units, 165 police stations and several other police infrastructure facilities since its inception in 1989.

FILE PIC

Reviewing the Department of Housing for All, Saini reiterated the government's commitment to providing housing to every eligible family. He directed officials to identify all remaining beneficiaries and prepare an action plan to ensure housing coverage. He also warned of strict action against officials if ineligible persons were found to have benefited from housing schemes.

Director General of the department, J. Ganesan informed the CM that housing assistance worth about Rs 2,375 crore has been provided to 2.31 lakh families under various schemes. He said 10,649 plots and flats are ready for allotment. Saini also directed the department to display beneficiary lists in gram panchayats to ensure transparency and facilitate public verification. MPOST

GST LEADS GROWTH

UP: Revenue collection in May rises by ₹2,371 cr

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Uttar Pradesh recorded a strong increase in revenue collections in May 2026, with receipts from key tax and non-tax revenue sources rising by Rs 2,371 crore compared to the same month last year, reflecting continued momentum in the state's economy.

According to the state government, revenue from major tax and non-tax heads stood at Rs 20,491 crore in May 2026, up from Rs 18,120 crore in May 2025.

State Finance Minister Suresh Kumar Khanna said the increase was driven primarily by higher Goods and Services Tax (GST) collections. GST revenue rose to Rs 7,551 crore in May 2026 from Rs 5,209 crore a year earlier, registering a jump of Rs 2,342 crore.

INSIGHT

- Revenue from major tax and non-tax heads stood at Rs 20,491 crore in May 2026, up from Rs 18,120 crore in May 2025
- GST revenue rose to Rs 7,551 crore in May 2026 from Rs 5,209 crore a year earlier, registering a jump of Rs 2,342 crore

Revenue from stamp duty and registration reached Rs 2,994 crore, an increase of Rs 36 crore over the previous year, while collections from the transport department rose by Rs 187 crore to Rs 1,228 crore. Value Added Tax (VAT) collections stood at Rs 3,010 crore and excise revenue at Rs 5,388 crore during the month.

The government said tax revenue collections during the first two months of the 2026-27 financial year reached Rs 41,621.54 crore against a target of Rs 55,641.02 crore, achieving 74.8 percent of the annual target for the period.

Under the state tax category, collections stood at Rs 21,452.89 crore against a target of Rs 34,054.25 crore, translating into 63 percent achievement. GST collections reached Rs 17,334.35 crore against a target of Rs 27,676.45 crore, or 62.6 percent of the goal.

Among major revenue-generating departments, excise recorded one of the strongest performances. Collections reached Rs 10,638.65 crore by May-end against a target of Rs 11,200 crore, achieving nearly 95 percent of the target.

The transport department exceeded its target, collecting Rs 2,544.92 crore against a target of Rs 2,529.28 crore, achieving 100.6 percent. The energy department also outperformed expectations, generating Rs 1,074.20 crore against a target of Rs 785.84 crore, achieving 136.7 percent of the target.

The stamp and registration department collected Rs 5,864.35 crore against a target of Rs 6,949.10 crore, achieving 84.4 percent of the target.

India hosts first meeting of BRICS Expert Network on Asset Recovery

Member nations discuss stronger coordination & information exchange

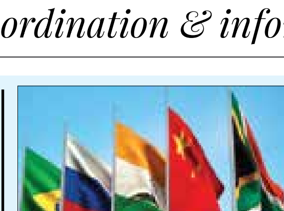
OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India, under its 2026 BRICS Presidency, hosted the inaugural meeting of the BRICS Expert Network on Asset Recovery in New Delhi, bringing together representatives from all BRICS member countries to strengthen cooperation in tracing, freezing and recovering assets derived from corruption and financial crimes.

The meeting, convened by the Directorate of Enforcement (ED), formed part of ongoing BRICS efforts to enhance anti-corruption cooperation and improve mechanisms for recovering illicit assets across jurisdictions. Discussions focused on practical challenges faced by countries in asset recovery investigations and ways to strengthen information-sharing and coordination among enforcement agencies.

KEY POINTS

- The meeting, convened by the Directorate of Enforcement (ED), formed part of ongoing BRICS efforts to enhance anti-corruption cooperation and improve mechanisms for recovering illicit assets across jurisdictions
- Discussions focused on practical challenges faced by countries in asset recovery



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

investigations and ways to strengthen information-sharing and coordination among enforcement agencies

- The discussions underscored the need for timely information exchange

Addressing the gathering, Enforcement Directorate Director Rahul Navin highlighted the growing importance of asset recovery in combating corruption and money laundering. He noted that financial crimes increasingly involve complex cross-border networks, making international cooperation essential for tracing and repatriating illicit proceeds. The Director also outlined India's experience under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002. According to him, assets worth nearly USD 25 billion have been attached or frozen under the law, while assets valued at approximately USD 6.6 billion have been restored to legitimate claimants and victims.

Delegates exchanged views on strengthening institutional frameworks and developing efficient channels for cooperation outside traditional legal assistance mechanisms. The discussions underscored the need for timely information exchange and greater coordination among investigative agencies to address the evolving nature of financial crimes.

A key outcome of the meeting was the agreement among BRICS countries to adopt a standard template proposed by India for sharing information related to recovered assets. Member nations also agreed to hold an in-person meeting of the Expert Network in the near future to further deepen cooperation and review progress.

Participants emphasised the importance of regular capacity-building and training programmes to equip investigators and enforcement agencies with the skills required to tackle increasingly sophisticated financial crimes.

The meeting reaffirmed the commitment of BRICS countries to strengthen collaboration based on mutual trust and in line with the principles of the United Nations Convention against Corruption (UNCAC). Officials noted that criminals often move illicit assets across borders to evade detection, making international cooperation crucial for tracing, freezing and returning such assets.

Researchers make major green hydrogen discovery

NEW DELHI: Indian scientists have made a breakthrough in understanding a key catalyst used in green hydrogen production, a development that could lead to cheaper and more efficient clean energy technologies.

A team led by Dr Neena S. John and PhD scholar Palash Jyoti Gogoi of the Centre for Nano and Soft Matter Sciences (CeNS), Bengaluru, along with researchers from Kiel University, Germany, and the Indo-Korea Science and Technology Center (IKST), Bengaluru, studied the behaviour of molybdenum carbide (Mo_2C) during water-splitting reactions. Hydrogen is considered a clean fuel of the future, and its production through water electrolysis depends heavily on catalysts. Contrary to the long-held belief that catalysts remain structurally stable, the study found that Mo_2C undergoes dynamic reconstruction during hydrogen evolution, forming oxygen-deficient molybdenum oxide domains that significantly improve its activity and stability. MPOST

Nation Briefs

FOREIGN CURRENCY WORTH RS 1.39 CR SEIZED FROM FLYER AT MUMBAI AIRPORT

MUMBAI: Airport security personnel at Mumbai Airport seized foreign currency worth about Rs 1.39 crore from an international passenger during routine screening at Terminal-2 in the early hours of Thursday. The cash, amounting to 145,000 US dollars, was detected when a screener noticed a suspicious image on an X-ray monitor while examining carry-on baggage. During a subsequent inspection, officials recovered the undeclared currency concealed among the passenger's belongings. The traveller, a citizen of Chad, was travelling on an Ethiopian Airlines flight from Mumbai to Addis Ababa. The Air Intelligence Unit (AIU) and Customs department later took custody of the passenger and seized currency, and launched an investigation.

UP: 406 KG CANNABIS SEIZED, 4 HELD

DEORIA: The Narcotics Control Bureau and the Uttar Pradesh Special Task Force busted an interstate ganja trafficking network in Deoria district, seizing over 406 kg of cannabis and arresting four alleged traffickers. Acting on specific intelligence, officials intercepted a Mahindra Bolero here on Wednesday and recovered around 202 kg of ganja concealed in secret compartments. Two persons were arrested at the spot. Subsequent raids led to the seizure of another 204.8 kg of cannabis and the arrest of two more suspects. Preliminary investigations suggest the consignment originated in Assam's Tezpur and was being transported through Uttar Pradesh for further distribution.

EDITORIAL

COST OF LOOKING AWAY

The allegations levelled by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) against Rajesh Exports are not merely about one company, one promoter, or one disputed set of financial statements. They strike at the heart of a larger and more uncomfortable question: how effectively are India's financial markets protected from corporate opacity and governance failures? The regulator's interim findings suggest that revenues running into an astonishing ₹15.15 lakh crore may have been misrepresented over a period of five years through overseas subsidiaries whose operations were allegedly shielded from public scrutiny. Rajesh Exports has strongly denied wrongdoing and insists that the matter stems from a misunderstanding regarding accounting treatment. It is entitled to present its defence, and due process must be respected. Yet the scale of the allegations is so extraordinary that they cannot be dismissed as a routine regulatory dispute. If even a fraction of the regulator's concerns are ultimately upheld, the case could rank among the most significant corporate governance failures witnessed in recent Indian market history.

What makes the episode particularly troubling is not only the alleged manipulation of numbers but the prolonged period during which warning signals appeared to go unnoticed by large sections of the investment community. The company's market value had already been in a prolonged decline long before SEBI's intervention. Its share price had been steadily eroding despite reported revenues that ostensibly suggested a thriving enterprise. Such disconnects between reported financial performance and market behaviour often deserve closer scrutiny. Markets are not always efficient, but persistent divergence between earnings narratives and investor confidence frequently reflects concerns that are not immediately visible in annual reports. The Rajesh Exports episode once again highlights a recurring weakness in Indian equity investing: an excessive focus on headline revenue and profit figures while paying inadequate attention to cash flows, disclosures, related-party transactions, and the quality of earnings. Investors often celebrate size without questioning substance. In many cases, the numbers tell one story while the cash tells another.

The fallout extends far beyond a single corporate entity. Nearly two lakh shareholders are now caught in a situation where uncertainty has become the dominant factor governing valuation. Retail investors, who constitute a substantial portion of the company's ownership, face the prospect of significant wealth destruction. The presence of institutional investors, including Life Insurance Corporation of India, only deepens concerns because such investments indirectly represent the savings and financial security of millions of ordinary Indians. When governance concerns emerge in listed companies, the damage is not confined to balance sheets. It erodes trust—the most valuable currency in capital markets. Retail participation in Indian equities has surged dramatically over the past decade, aided by digital platforms, financial literacy campaigns, and growing confidence in India's economic prospects. However, confidence is fragile. Every major governance scandal reinforces the perception among small investors that the playing field remains uneven and that sophisticated insiders often possess information advantages unavailable to the broader market.

At the same time, the case also underscores the critical importance of a vigilant and empowered regulator. India's securities markets have grown into one of the world's largest and most dynamic investment ecosystems. Such growth inevitably attracts bad actors alongside genuine entrepreneurs. The regulator's role is not merely punitive; it is preventive. SEBI's intervention demonstrates that disclosure obligations cannot be circumvented through complex international corporate structures, confidentiality claims, or opaque subsidiary arrangements. Globalisation cannot become an excuse for opacity. If a company seeks capital from Indian investors, it must remain fully accountable to Indian disclosure standards irrespective of where its subsidiaries operate. The allegations relating to undisclosed transactions, questionable revenue reporting, and the alleged routing of corporate funds to promoter-linked activities raise fundamental governance concerns that go beyond technical accounting disagreements. Regulators must pursue such matters with rigour, independence, and speed. Equally important, investigations should conclude within a reasonable timeframe so that uncertainty does not linger indefinitely over investors and the company alike.

The broader lesson from the Rajesh Exports controversy is that corporate governance cannot be treated as a secondary consideration behind growth stories and ambitious revenue figures. In bull markets, investors often become enamoured with narratives of expansion, global reach, and market leadership. Yet history repeatedly shows that governance failures eventually overwhelm even the most impressive financial claims. For investors, the episode serves as a reminder that scrutiny of management credibility, transparency, auditor quality, and cash generation is as important as analysing earnings growth. For policymakers, it reinforces the need for stronger disclosure frameworks and enhanced oversight of complex multinational structures. And for corporate India, it is a warning that trust, once lost, is extraordinarily difficult to rebuild. The success of India's capital markets depends not merely on attracting investment but on sustaining confidence that every listed company, regardless of size or influence, is subject to the same standards of honesty and accountability. In the final analysis, markets can absorb losses. What they struggle to recover from is the erosion of trust.

ENERGY SECURITY

The Price of Dependence

Rising oil prices, geopolitical turmoil and supply risks are forcing India to rethink energy security, accelerate renewables and build resilience against future global shocks

JOHN FELIX RAJ & SOVIK MUKHERJEE

JOHN FELIX RAJ IS THE VICE CHANCELLOR, AND SOVIK MUKHERJEE IS AN ASSISTANT PROFESSOR OF ECONOMICS, BOTH AT ST. XAVIER'S UNIVERSITY, KOLKATA

> The shock is actively forcing India to build up its strategic reserves, diversify its diplomatic partnerships, and aggressively scale its renewable infrastructure

The escalating conflict in West Asia has triggered more than just regional geopolitical instability — it has exposed one of India's deepest economic vulnerabilities. As tensions involving Iran continue to disrupt global energy markets and threaten critical shipping lanes around the Strait of Hormuz, New Delhi is being forced to fundamentally rethink its approach to energy security.

For a country that imports nearly 90 per cent of its crude oil requirements, the current crisis is not merely a localised issue of rising fuel prices. It has rapidly evolved into a test of economic resilience, national security, and long-term strategic survival.

For years, India's economic growth story relied on stable, uninterrupted access to imported energy. Cheap oil powered its transportation network, fueled manufacturing, accelerated infrastructure expansion, and sustained rising consumer demand. However, the energy shock of 2026 has served as a stark reminder of how swiftly global conflicts can destabilise domestic economic stability.

The Iran Conflict and the Global Oil Shock

The ongoing conflict in Iran has fundamentally transformed global energy markets. Attacks on regional infrastructure, heightened fears of shipping disruptions, and military escalation near the Strait of Hormuz have sent crude oil prices soaring throughout 2026. Because nearly one-fifth of the world's oil trade passes through this narrow chokepoint, even the mere threat of disruption triggers panic across international trading desks.

Market Impact: Brent crude crossed the USD 110 per barrel threshold in early May before stabilising slightly, further compounding fiscal pressure on major oil-importing economies like India.

This surging import bill has widened the trade deficit and amplified concerns around inflation. In India, retail petrol and diesel prices have climbed steadily, breaching the Rs 100-per-litre mark in several major cities. Consequently, transportation and logistics costs have surged, creating an inflationary domino effect impacting everything from essential groceries and food delivery to airline tariffs and public transit.

Unlike previous, short-lived oil shocks, the current crisis is driven by prolonged geopolitical uncertainty rather than a temporary supply bottleneck. Markets are pricing in the reality that instability in the Gulf may persist for months, if not years. This protracted uncertainty is forcing Indian policymakers to look beyond short-term economic firefighting toward a wholesale strategic overhaul of the nation's energy dependency.

India's systemic reliance on imported crude makes its economy uniquely sensitive to global energy volatility

The Human Cost: Households under Pressure

India's systemic reliance on imported crude makes its economy uniquely sensitive to global energy volatility. Every uptick in crude prices directly weakens the Indian Rupee against the US Dollar, driving up the cost of all other imports and aggravating fiscal stress.

Today, these macroeconomic consequences are visibly playing out in the daily lives of citizens:

- **Supply Chain Inflation:** Surging freight costs have pushed up the prices of daily essentials, including vegetables, milk, and staple goods across urban and rural markets alike.
- **Household Strains:** Rising costs for LPG cylinders, electricity bills, and daily commutes are squeezing the disposable income of middle-class and lower-income families.
- **The Gig & MSME Crunch:** Gig workers, cab drivers, truck operators, and small business owners are watching their profit margins swallowed by non-negotiable fuel overheads.

What appears as a percentage point on a macroeconomic ledger is a tangible financial burden inside Indian homes. Recognising this strain on transportation networks, several state governments and private enterprises have re-instituted remote and hybrid work arrangements — positioning remote work not just as a productivity tool, but as a tactical measure for fuel conservation and urban sustainability.

Geopolitical Realignment and Strategic Alliances

In response to the crisis, New Delhi has intensified its energy diplomacy, particularly within the Gulf cooperation frameworks. Prime Minister Narendra Modi's recent high-level visit to Abu Dhabi yielded critical bilateral agreements focused on energy diversification, renewable energy investment, and long-term supply guarantees.

Simultaneously, India has expanded its clean energy and green technology partnerships with European nations, including the Netherlands, Sweden, Norway, and Italy.

A key milestone is India's deepening cooperation with ADNOC (Abu Dhabi National Oil Company) to expand commercial and strategic crude storage within Indian facilities. This highlights a paradigm shift: India is moving away from a transactional focus on low-cost imports toward a strategic prioritisation of supply security and resilience.

Accelerating the development of India's Strategic Petroleum Reserve (SPR) system brings the nation in line with global giants like the United States and China, who have long maintained massive emergency stockpiles to cushion against geopolitical shocks.

Renewable Energy as a Core National Security Pillar

Perhaps the most significant structural shift accelerated by the 2026 crisis is the transition of renewable energy from an environmental aspiration to a hard-nosed national security imperative.

Until recently, India's clean energy goals were primarily framed around climate commitments and international sustainability metrics. Today, they are driven by the cold calculus of sovereign autonomy. The strategic equation is straightforward:

{Reduced Fossil Fuel Dependence} = {Lower Exposure to Geopolitical Shocks}

This logic has supercharged capital deployment into utility-scale solar infrastructure, electric mobility, green hydrogen, and advanced ethanol-blended fuels. While India already ranks among the world's top renewable energy producers, policymakers now view the green transition fundamentally as an economic shield. By heavily incentivising the domestic manufacturing of clean-tech components — particularly through expanded Production Linked Incentive (PLI) schemes for solar cells and advanced chemistry cell batteries — India aims to break its reliance on foreign supply chains simultaneously.

In a twist of historical irony, the geopolitical friction in West Asia has injected far more urgency into India's green transition than decades of global climate summits ever could.

New Era of Energy Sovereignty

The energy crisis of 2026 has served as an undeniable wake-up call. The volatility in West Asia has laid bare the vulnerabilities of a fossil-fuel-dependent economy, proving that geopolitical ripples in the Middle East directly impact household budgets across India.

However, crises often act as catalysts. This shock is actively forcing India to build up its strategic reserves, diversify its diplomatic partnerships, and aggressively scale its renewable infrastructure. As the era of cheap, predictable fossil fuels draws to a close, India's ultimate challenge is not just weathering the immediate storm, but anchoring itself in a future where energy policy, economic stability, and national defense are inextricably linked.

Views expressed are personal

STRATEGIC TIGHTROPE

Gulf's Shifting Equations

The struggle over Hormuz is reshaping power equations across West Asia, creating opportunities for Pakistan and fresh challenges for India

ASLAM KHAN

THE WRITER IS A PROFESSOR IN THE NELSON MANDELA CENTRE FOR PEACE AND CONFLICT RESOLUTION, JAMIA MILLIA ISLAMIA

> For India, the crisis is as much about geopolitical positioning as it is about oil security

The long-standing conflict between the US and Iran seems to be in a phase of strategic stalemate, where both adversaries are engaging in sporadic kinetic exchanges while pursuing coercive bargaining. During April and May, both parties clashed over their respective positions on freedom of navigation through the Strait of Hormuz and Iran's nuclear programme, which has disturbed the global energy market, escalated great-power competition, and imposed acute strategic costs on the wider Indo-Pacific region.

On March 25, the United States presented a 15-point proposal to Iran via Pakistan's Army Chief, Asim Munir. This negotiation framework demanded immediate free navigation through the Strait of Hormuz, the dismantling of Iran's nuclear programme, the halting of uranium enrichment activities, the surrender of its highly enriched uranium (HEU) stockpile, the granting of inspection access to the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) for its nuclear facilities, and the curtailment of its missile capabilities. This reflects the US doctrine of coercive diplomacy.

Iran's strategic narrative views the conflict as an externally imposed war of aggression against its sovereignty. In response to the US proposal, Iran put forward a new multi-phased framework. In the first phase of talks, Iran demanded the immediate lifting of the US naval blockade on Iranian ports and, concurrently, US acknowledgement of Iran's legal authority over the Strait of Hormuz. While presenting its proposal to the US, Iran agreed to engage in discussions regarding the nuclear issue during the second phase. However, the US was not convinced by Iran's revised multi-phase proposal and firmly maintained its own demands.

Although the initial talks in Islamabad on April 11–12, 2026, were unsuccessful, they brought into the limelight the specific issues on which both sides remained uncompromising—the matter of the nuclear programme and the issue of control over the Strait of Hormuz. The second round of talks between Iran and the US, which was anticipated in Islamabad on April 21, also failed.

Recently, on May 24, US President Donald Trump announced that a memorandum of understanding (MoU) between the US and Iran had been "largely negotiated." The agreement includes a 60-day ceasefire extension, the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz without the toll regime planned by the Iranian government, the lifting of the naval blockade on Iranian ports imposed on April 13, and the partial release of Iranian assets. Notably, the issue of Iran's nuclear programme has been deferred to a subsequent phase of negotiations. This suggests that maritime and economic deliverables are more achievable than preventing the development of nuclear warheads.

Beyond oil and shipping lanes, the Hormuz negotiations are becoming a contest over influence, connectivity and the future balance of power in Asia

The much-talked-about player in this negotiation effort is Pakistan, which has emerged as a principal mediator. On the one hand, Army Chief General Asim Munir has negotiated with a US delegation led by Vice President J.D. Vance, while on the other, Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi made two visits to Tehran on May 16–17 and May 20. It is noteworthy that although Pakistan has a limited presence in the West Asian region, it maintains durable security ties with Iran. The five-point peace initiative co-authored by Pakistan and China has elevated Pakistan's strategic standing globally. These mediation efforts have brought several benefits to Pakistan, including deeper relationships with both the US and China, as well as enhanced prestige in the international order.

A provisional settlement could help bring some relief to West Asia through the restoration of hydrocarbon flows and partial de-escalation in Lebanon and Yemen. This could also provide some reprieve to Gulf monarchies that have been destabilised by drone strikes targeting the Barakah nuclear facility in the UAE and Saudi airspace.

With respect to South Asia, the crisis carries uneven geopolitical consequences with significant implications for India's strategic interests. Pakistan could gain diplomatic and economic leverage through the strengthening of the China–Pakistan partnership and the possible emergence of a China–Pakistan–Iran energy corridor, thereby increasing its relevance in Eurasian connectivity and regional energy politics. For India, however, the crisis presents multiple strategic concerns. A renewed US–Pakistan engagement may reduce India's centrality in Washington's Indo-Pacific strategy at a time when New Delhi seeks stronger American support to balance China's expanding influence. Indian strategic discourse increasingly views prolonged instability in West Asia as a factor that could divert US military and diplomatic attention away from the Indo-Pacific. Consequently, India perceives the crisis not merely as a regional conflict but as one directly linked to its energy security, maritime interests, and long-term geopolitical ambitions. In response, India has accelerated efforts to diversify energy imports towards Russia, the UAE, and other Gulf partners while strengthening strategic petroleum reserves to mitigate disruptions caused by vulnerable chokepoints such as the Strait of Hormuz.

India's response reflects a carefully calibrated doctrine of strategic autonomy. With nearly 60 per cent of India's crude oil imports passing through the Strait of Hormuz, New Delhi adopted a cautious diplomatic posture by summoning Iran's ambassador while avoiding overt alignment with either bloc. India also declined to endorse the SCO statement condemning strikes on Iran, thereby preserving policy flexibility and protecting its strategic interests in the Chabahar Port project, which remains central to India's connectivity strategy towards Afghanistan and Central Asia. Simultaneously, India has intensified support for the India–Middle East–Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC) and expanded maritime cooperation with European and Gulf partners to reduce structural dependence on unstable routes. New Delhi increasingly recognises that a strengthened China–Pakistan–Iran axis could constrain India's strategic space, compelling it to move from excessive multilateral hedging towards more dependable and interest-based strategic partnerships.

The emerging ceasefire between the United States and Iran has evolved beyond a temporary suspension of hostilities into a broader effort to redesign Gulf security architecture and stabilise the wider West Asian order. The fragile truce reflects a recognition on both sides that prolonged confrontation has endangered global energy flows, intensified regional proxy conflicts, and deepened strategic uncertainty across the Indo-Pacific and Eurasia. Current negotiations increasingly revolve around three interconnected compromises: ensuring freedom of navigation through the Strait of Hormuz, calibrated sanctions relief and partial asset releases for Iran, and a monitored framework addressing Iran's nuclear programme, including possible third-party supervision of highly enriched uranium. Simultaneously, de-escalation in Lebanon and restraint among regional proxy actors have become essential components of sustaining the ceasefire. Pakistan's mediation efforts, supported by regional actors such as Qatar and quietly acknowledged by major powers, have opened a narrow but important diplomatic window for dialogue. However, the durability of this process remains uncertain, as unresolved disputes over sanctions, enrichment capabilities, and regional influence continue to threaten renewed escalation. It is important to see whether this process culminates in a peace agreement or triggers another cycle of escalation that will shape a new roadmap for the strategic contours of West Asia in the future.

Views expressed are personal

CLOUDS PROSPECTS FOR ENDING IRAN WAR

Hezbollah rejects latest truce pact as Israeli strikes kill 4 in Lebanon

BEIRUT: Hezbollah on Thursday rejected the latest ceasefire agreement reached between Israel and the Lebanese government, demanding a complete Israeli withdrawal. The announcement came as Israeli strikes killed at least four people, according to local authorities, and a UN peacekeeper was killed in the crossfire.

Hezbollah leader Naim Kassem, in a written statement read on TV, said the agreement's demand that Hezbollah fighters leave southern Lebanon under fire would mean "surrender, defeat and achieving the enemy's goals."

"What we are concerned about is an end to the aggression, ceasefire and Israel's withdrawal," he said. "We did not make any commitment to any party to stop resisting as long as there is occupation," he added.

The ongoing fighting in Lebanon, where Israeli forces have seized large swaths of the south, threatens efforts to end the Iran war and reopen the Strait of Hormuz, a key transit point for oil and gas whose closure has jolted the world economy. Iran has demanded that any lasting truce extend to Lebanon. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, who faces elections later this year, wants to press ahead with Israel's offensive until Hezbollah no longer poses a threat. Israeli troops have seized around a fifth of Lebanon since Hezbollah began launching rocket and drone attacks in solidarity with Iran days into the wider war.

A man checks a house that was being destroyed in an Israeli airstrike in Burj al-Shemali village near the southern port city of Tyre AP/PTI

Highlights

» Iran has demanded that any lasting truce extend to Lebanon

» Israeli troops have seized around a fifth of Lebanon since Hezbollah began launching rocket and drone attacks

» Netanyahu wants to press ahead with Israel's offensive until Hezbollah no longer poses a threat

US President Donald Trump, who faced a rare rebuke from Congress on Wednesday, has sought to downplay the diplomatic deadlock and the failure of declared ceasefires to end the fighting, telling reporters that in the Middle East, "a ceasefire is when you're shooting in a more moderate manner."

A Serbian peacekeeper was killed, and two other peacekeepers were wounded, when a mortar struck their location near Marjayoun, a Christian-majority town that has seen intense fighting, according to the UN mission, known as UNIFIL, and Serbia's Defence Ministry.

Neither said whether the mortar fire came from Israel or Hezbollah. AGENCIES

SL: 12 killed in fire at elderly care home; owner held

COLOMBO: At least 12 people were killed and seven others injured after a fire broke out at an elderly care home in Sri Lanka, police said Thursday.

The owner of the elderly care home, Senehase Kadalla Mavupiya Savana' (the nest of affection), was arrested on Thursday and later remanded till June 11 by a magistrate.

The blaze erupted at around 5:30 pm on Wednesday at the elderly care home in Kalutara district's Anguruwatota, about 65 kilometres southeast of Colombo.

Police said 10 residents were found dead at the premises, while two succumbed to injuries after they were admitted to the Horana Base Hospital. There were more than 70 elderly residents at the facility when the fire broke out. The fire was doused with the assistance of residents and police. AGENCIES

Ukraine's drone strikes set gloomy tone for Putin's economic showcase

ST PETERSBURG: A massive black cloud rising above the St Petersburg skyline from a Ukrainian drone strike set a gloomy tone for the opening of President Vladimir Putin's annual showcase of Russia's economic achievements.

With Putin set to arrive Thursday in his hometown that is hosting the St Petersburg International Economic Forum, the Ukrainian attack a day earlier that set an oil terminal ablaze was another embarrassing blow to his efforts to minimise the impact of the 4-year-old conflict and cast it as a distant event with no effect on Russian daily life.

The attack, which also targeted a naval base near Russia's second-largest city on the Gulf of Finland, underlined Ukraine's growing capability to hit deep inside its neighbour and demonstrated that even the heavily protected city where Putin was born is increasingly vulnerable.

Scores of flights were delayed or diverted at St Petersburg's airport and authorities cut cellphone internet service to try to prevent drone attacks.

Putin had scaled down Russia's annual Victory Day parade on May 9, fearing Ukrainian drone strikes. Days later, a massive drone attack on Moscow's suburbs killed three and showed the capital's vulnerability.

Russian President Vladimir Putin

Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov said Russia's forces were pressing inside Ukraine "in order to prevent such attacks" like the one on St Petersburg. He noted that "systematic" strikes on Kyiv that Russia threatened last week are underway.

On Tuesday, Russia hit Kyiv and other Ukrainian cities with hundreds of drones and dozens of missiles, killing 23 and wounding 151 others.

Putin has used the forum to showcase his country's economic advances and encourage foreign investment. Often styled as the Russian version of the World Economic Forum in Davos, Switzerland, it usually draws tens of thousands of delegates from around the world.

While Western officials and business people have stayed away from the forum after Putin sent troops into Ukraine in 2022, Russia has sought to attract more guests from other regions to underline its declared goal of promoting a "multipolar world".

Saudi Arabia, which is a special guest this year, has sent a large delegation. AGENCIES

'Strikes kill 9 overnight in Gaza'

DEIR AL-BALAH: Israeli strikes in Gaza killed at least nine Palestinians overnight, a hospital said Thursday, even as much of the world's attention was focused on the fighting between Israel and Hezbollah in Lebanon.

The nine people were killed in at least four separate strikes in Gaza City, according to Shifa Hospital, which received the bodies. The hospital said the victims included two women and two children.

REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

Footage of one of the strikes showed a massive hole in an upper floor in what appeared to be a residential apartment building. The blast blew holes through interior walls and scattered blood-stained belongings across the room and into the street. "They say the war has stopped, but the war has not stopped," said Walid Shbeir, the uncle of one of the men killed in the strikes, as family members sobbed over the bodies of the victims at the hospital. "Every night there is killing, and we have martyrs. Every night, in the morning, in the evening, and at night, this killing is continuous for us."

The Israeli military did not immediately comment on the strikes. Last week, Israel killed the top Hamas military leader, two weeks after strikes that killed his predecessor. The fatalities were the latest in the coastal enclave since an October ceasefire deal attempted to halt a more than two-year war between Israel and the Palestinian militant Hamas group in Gaza. AGENCIES

Congo reports attack on Ebola burial team

KINSHASA: Residents attacked an Ebola burial team in eastern Democratic Republic of Congo's South Kivu province this week, forcing responders to abandon a coffin and raising fears of further transmission, the health ministry said.

The assault took place on Monday in Katana of the provincial capital Bukavu, according to the ministry and the head of a local hospital reached by Reuters. AGENCIES

Sherpa guide rescued after going missing for a week on Mt. Everest

KATHMANDU: A Sherpa guide was found alive on Mount Everest a week after he went missing, and a helicopter was flying him to a hospital on Thursday, rescuers said.

Dawa Sherpa was last seen around May 29 descending the mountain, but he did not make it to base camp even though his client did.

The pair were among the last climbers on the mountain as the climbing season came to an end and the route was dismantled.

Dawa was located by a cleaning crew Thursday morning as he was crawling down the snowy slopes around the Khumbu Icefall just above the base camp, said Pemba Sherpa of 8K Expeditions, which was coordinating the search. He was quickly carried down to safety and given food and water.

A rescue helicopter picked him up and was flying him to a hospital.

Though the Sherpa guide had been missing since last week, there was a delay in organising a search team. AGENCIES

Centre rolling out 100 ethanol fuel stations in Delhi-NCR, Maha: Puri

Petroleum & Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri expressed hope to expand this network of ethanol fuel stations to 500 by end of 2026

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The government is rolling out 50-100 ethanol fuel stations in Delhi-NCR, Pune, Mumbai and Nagpur, with an aim to reduce imports of fossil fuels, Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri said on Thursday.

He expressed hope to expand this network of ethanol fuel stations to 500 by the end of 2026.

Speaking on the sidelines of the launch of India's first flex fuel car by Maruti Suzuki, Puri said he anticipates that by the end of 2027, India will have 5,000 ethanol fuel stations.

"I think we are starting with about 50 to 100 (ethanol) dispensing stations in Delhi-NCR region, Pune, Mumbai, and Nagpur, etc. This 50-100 (ethanol) dispensing stations will hopefully go up to 500 towards the end of 2026," he said. Puri said if the Euro VI standard vehicle can be made compliant with E100, it will also help in reducing import of fossil fuels, which is around $120 billion.

Puri said the government is also working on supportive measures such as pricing support, road tax concessions, availability of E85 testing fuel, special identifiers for FFVs and retail outlets, consumer awareness initiatives, and development of storage and dispensing infrastructure to increase adoption.

"This is not merely a transition in fuel, but it is the creation of a complete ecosystem for cleaner mobility, stronger energy security, and greater self-reliance," he said.

Responding to a question on losses OMCs are making every day due to buying crude, gas and LPG at higher prices and shielding consumers by selling the three retail fuels at lower prices, he said, "They are still quite high... Rs 500-550 crore per day loss."

The minister said 60 per cent of India's LPG and 90 per cent of India's crude oil was coming via the Strait of Hormuz.

"In the 93 or 94 days that have elapsed (after the attack of the US and Israel on Iran on February 28), there has not been a single dry out anywhere. There has been no shortage," Puri claimed.

He, however, asserted that there have been individuals who have tried to take advantage of that situation by spreading false news by creating or conspiring to create artificial shortages when none existed.

Puri said India comes next to Japan as a country with the lowest increase in fuel prices.

The minister pointed out that if half the new (two-wheeler and four-wheeler) vehicles which come out are flex fuel-compliant, then India can unlock 311.8 crore litres of additional ethanol demand and Rs 12,403 crore additional income for farmers.

He noted that the country has already raised ethanol blending in petrol from 1.5 per cent in 2014 to 20 per cent today, resulting in foreign exchange savings of Rs 1.84 lakh crore through the substitution of 302 lakh metric tonnes of crude oil.

The minister said the entry of flex-fuel technology into the passenger vehicle segment is not merely a product launch, but also the beginning of a new chapter in India's energy transition. Puri noted that India has nearly 37 lakh passenger vehicles representing the aspirations of middle-class India and the future of personal mobility.

Large-scale adoption of flex-fuel technology in this segment can significantly multiply the impact of ethanol-based mobility, he added.

Puri credited the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi for balancing the three key pillars of India's energy strategy -- availability, affordability and sustainability.

On availability, he highlighted that India maintained uninterrupted supplies of crude oil, LPG and natural gas despite global volatility. "India increased domestic LPG production from 32 TMT per day pre-crisis to nearly 52 TMT per day, while also expanding the transition towards piped natural gas and CNG," the minister said.

On affordability, the minister said India recorded one of the lowest increases in fuel prices globally. He recalled the prime minister's decision to reduce central excise duties on petrol and diesel by Rs 10 per litre to provide relief to consumers.

Talking about sustainability, Puri recalled his earlier experience in Brazil and the USA, where ethanol blending based on sugar and maize had already demonstrated success.

He said India's ethanol blending programme has become one of the most successful energy transition initiatives.

Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri

Puri said he anticipates that by the end of 2027, India will have 5,000 ethanol fuel stations

Highlights

- 'If the Euro VI standard vehicle can be made compliant with E100, it will also help in reducing fossil fuel imports, which is around $120 billion'
- Responding to a question on losses OMCs are making every day, he said, 'They are still quite high... Rs 500-550 crore per day loss'
- The minister said 60 per cent of India's LPG and 90 per cent of India's crude oil was coming via the Strait of Hormuz

India has potential to become energy exporter, says Gadkari

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Union Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari on Thursday said India now has the potential to shift from being an energy-importing nation to an energy exporter, with the changing geopolitical scenario due to the West Asia crisis, and the country's progress on ethanol, hydrogen and sustainable aviation fuel.

Speaking at the launch of Maruti Suzuki's first flex fuel car in India, Gadkari further said India's dependence on fossil fuels is both an economic burden, as Rs 22 lakh crore is spent annually on fuel imports and an environmental hazard, making clean energy adoption crucial for the nation's progress.

"We now have the potential to go from an energy-importing nation to an energy-exporting nation," he said.

The road transport and highways minister said India is currently producing 78,000 tonnes of sustainable aviation fuel (SAF) per year, and could become a net SAF exporter within two years.

Gadkari added that the government intends to eventually run fighter jets and helicopters on SAF as well.

The minister also noted that air pollution is a problem in India, and the transport sector is responsible for 40 per cent of pollution in the country.

"To reduce pollution in the country, we should promote alternative fuels, including ethanol and CNG," he added.

The minister stated that since ethanol is surplus in the country, the move to make ethanol from corn has generated an additional income of Rs 45,000 crore for farmers of Uttar Pradesh and Bihar.

"When we decided to make ethanol from corn, the corn's market price was Rs 1,200 per quintal, and MSP was Rs 1,800 per quintal. After the decision, corn's price went up to Rs 2,800 per quintal.

"Rs 45,000 crore additional went into the pockets of farmers from Uttar Pradesh and Bihar," he said.

Noting that hydrogen is the fuel of the future, Gadkari said the government has identified 10 highway stretches in different parts of the country for plying green hydrogen-powered trucks with an aim to reduce vehicular pollution.

The identified highway stretches include Greater Noida-Delhi-Agra, Bhubaneswar-Puri-Konark, Ahmedabad-Vadodara-Surat, Sahibabad-Faridabad-Delhi, Jamshedpur-Kalinganagar, Thiruvananthapuram-Kochi, and Jamnagar-Ahmedabad, among others.

Referring to contributions of the automobile sector in India's economic growth, he said this sector contributes maximum GST to the Centre and state governments, and also provides employment to 4.5 crore youth.

"When I took charge as transport minister, the size of the Indian automobile industry was Rs 14 lakh crore. The size of the Indian automobile industry now is Rs 23 lakh crore," Gadkari said.

Union Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari

'India's dependence on fossil fuels is an economic burden, as Rs 22 lakh crore is spent annually on fuel imports'

Key Points

- 'India is currently producing 78,000 tonnes of SAF per year and could become a net SAF exporter within two years'
- Gadkari added that the govt intends to eventually run fighter jets and helicopters on SAF as well
- Gadkari also noted that air pollution is a problem in India, and the transport sector is responsible for 40 per cent of pollution

INVESTMENT FROM US DOUBLES

FDI inflows in Indian equities rise 18% to $58.84 bn in last fiscal year

NEW DELHI: Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) equity inflows into India rose 18 per cent to $58.84 billion in 2025-26, with investments from the United States more than doubling during the last financial year.

FDI from the US rose to $11.17 billion in 2025-26 from $5.45 billion in 2024-25, according to the data released by the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade.

In the January-March quarter of 2025-26, the FDI equity investments grew 17.5 per cent to $10.9 billion.

Total FDI, which includes equity inflows, reinvested earnings and other capital, increased 17 per cent to $94.5 billion.

Singapore was the largest source of FDI during the period, contributing $19.8 billion.

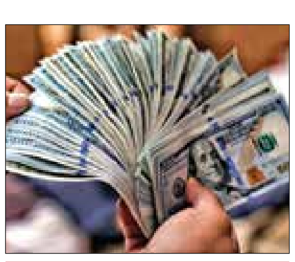
It was followed by the US, Mauritius ($6.57 billion), Japan ($3.74 billion), and the Netherlands ($3.37 billion).

Sector-wise, inflows during April-December this fiscal in computer software and hardware rose to $13.94 billion, which was followed by the inflow in services at $10 billion, and trading at $4 billion.

Inflow in the non-conventional energy sector stood at $3 billion during the period.

Among states, the data showed, Maharashtra received the highest inflow of $18.41 billion during the period.

It was followed by Karnataka ($12.93 billion) and Gujarat ($5.71 billion). PTI



In the January-March quarter of 2025-26, the FDI equity investments grew 17.5 per cent to $10.9 billion

BARS CEO FROM DEALING IN COMPANY'S SECURITIES

Rajesh Exports inflated revenue by ₹15L cr: Sebi

NEW DELHI: Market regulator Sebi has accused gold refiner and jewellery manufacturer Rajesh Exports Ltd (REL) of prima facie inflating its consolidated revenue by over Rs 15.15 lakh crore during FY21-FY25 through revenues attributed to overseas subsidiaries, particularly Switzerland-based Valcambi SA.

In an interim order, Sebi said REL reported consolidated revenue of about Rs 15.18 lakh crore over the five-year period, with nearly 99.8 per cent attributed to subsidiaries. However, these figures could not be reconciled with Valcambi SA's audited standalone financial statements, which showed only a fraction of the reported revenue.

The regulator highlighted a sharp mismatch between Valcambi's standalone accounts and revenues disclosed by REL and its intermediary holding company, Global Gold Refineries (GGR).

For instance, in 2023, Valcambi reported revenue of around Rs 543 crore, while GGR and REL reported revenues of about Rs 2.93 lakh crore and Rs 2.81 lakh crore, respectively.

REL argued that Valcambi recorded only processing income, while GGR recognised the gross value of gold transactions.

Sebi, however, found the explanation prima facie unsustainable, noting the absence of supporting evidence such as accounting opinions, ownership records, inter-company agreements and reconciliation statements.

According to Sebi, the accounting treatment appeared "internally inconsistent, commercially implausible and unsupported by verifiable underlying records".

The regulator also noted that although 97-99 per cent of REL's revenues were claimed to originate from overseas subsidiaries, the company did not publicly disclose their financial statements and failed to furnish key data sought during the investigation.

Calling the alleged inflation "egregious and unheard of", Sebi barred promoter and CEO Rajesh Mehta from dealing in the company's securities and directed the firm to ensure true and fair disclosures.

Rajesh Exports denied any wrongdoing, stating that its reported revenues were accurate and attributing the issue to a "communication gap and confusion" with the regulator.

The investigation stemmed from a shareholder complaint received in March 2024. AGENCIES

'REL reported consolidated revenue of about Rs 15.18 lakh cr over five-year, with 99.8% attributed to subsidiaries'

IndiGo suspends ops to 6 int'l destinations

MUMBAI: India's largest airline IndiGo on Thursday said it has temporarily suspended operations to six international destinations, including Hong Kong and Krabi, as part of network optimisation.

The budget carrier has decided to temporarily suspend services to Langkawi, Krabi, Ho Chi Minh, Hong Kong, and Shanghai starting July 1 and Siem Reap effective July 3 until September 30, IndiGo said in a statement.

The decision has been taken in view of a traditionally softer demand in the upcoming quarter and an incredibly challenging cost environment, it said.

IndiGo will resume bookings for all impacted services starting October 1, subject to an improved environment, it said.

The carrier also stated that it has managed to retain majority of its international operations — over 1,800 weekly international flights — despite this realignment.

"These measured changes are designed to align capacity with current market conditions and demand trends, while ensuring the airline maintains reliability and network integrity across its global destinations," the statement said.

The airline will continue to monitor the situation, given the elevated operating costs and continued airspace restrictions, the airline added. PTI

Vedanta Iron and Steel cuts 2.5 MT carbon emissions in 5 yrs via sustainability initiatives

The company's barge-based logistics network also helped reduce emissions

NEW DELHI: Vedanta Iron and Steel Ltd (VISL) on Thursday said it has reduced, avoided or sequestered nearly 2.5 million tonnes of carbon emissions over the past five years through a range of sustainability initiatives across its mining and steel operations.

Marking World Environment Day, the company highlighted measures including renewable energy adoption, cleaner logistics, electrification of equipment and ecosystem restoration as part of its decarbonisation strategy.

VISL said electric passenger vehicles, wheel loaders and forklifts deployed across operations now save nearly 800 kilolitres of diesel annually, significantly lowering greenhouse gas emissions. The company's barge-based logistics network also helped reduce emissions.

In FY26, barge operations were equivalent to eliminating around 2.1 lakh truck trips, saving 10.8 million litres of diesel and cutting nearly 28,900 tonnes of CO2 emissions. VISL generates a cumulative 100 MW of power through waste heat recovery systems at its pig iron plant in Goa and steel plant in Bokaro. The low-carbon power facilities have helped avoid about 2.4 million tonnes of CO2 emissions, the company said.

The company has also focused on ecological restoration. Its reclaimed Sanquelim mine in Goa, spread across more than 100 hectares, hosts around 7.5 lakh trees that sequester nearly 16,000 tonnes of CO2 annually.

Over three decades, the site has absorbed close to 4.8 lakh tonnes of CO2.

Additionally, VISL has planted over 75,000 trees under Miyawaki forest projects in Goa and Jharkhand, along with around three lakh trees through afforestation drives.

At its Bokaro steel plant, VISL is transitioning to piped natural gas in partnership with Indian Oil, a move expected to reduce emissions by about 1,500 tonnes of CO2 equivalent annually. AGENCIES

VISL generates cumulative 100 MW of power via waste heat recovery systems at its pig iron plant in Goa & steel plant in Bokaro

Vedanta says ED's FEMA search operation ends without penalty

NEW DELHI: Vedanta Ltd on Thursday said the Enforcement Directorate (ED) has concluded search operations at its premises under the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA), 1999, and that no penalty, restriction or sanction has been imposed on the company.

In a regulatory filing, Vedanta said the search commenced on June 1 at 12:15 pm and concluded on June 3 at 9:55 pm.

The company stated that its officials fully cooperated with the investigating agency and provided all information, documents and clarifications sought during the exercise.

Vedanta clarified that the ED has not imposed any penalty or restriction in connection with the matter. "There is no impact on financial, operational or other activities of the company," it said.

The disclosure follows reports that the ED had conducted searches at Vedanta Group locations as part of an investigation under foreign exchange laws. Vedanta Ltd, the group's listed Indian entity, has a market capitalisation of about Rs 1.3 lakh crore.

Its parent, UK-based Vedanta Resources, carries significant debt, estimated at around Rs 74,000 crore.

Over the years, the Indian subsidiary has made royalty and other payments to the overseas parent.

Vedanta shares ended 0.21 per cent lower at Rs 327.50 on the NSE on Thursday. AGENCIES

'There is no impact on financial, operational or other activities of the company,' it said

Maruti Suzuki launches India's first flex-fuel car

Flex-fuel car gives customers flexibility to run on any ethanol & petrol blend from E20 to E100

NEW DELHI: Maruti Suzuki India on Thursday launched the country's first flex-fuel passenger car, the Wagon R, capable of running on any blend of ethanol and petrol from E20 to E100.

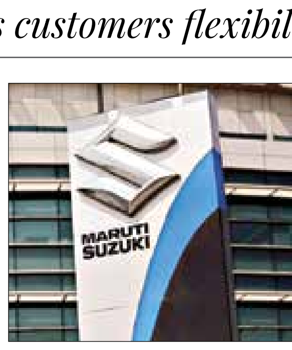
The vehicle is equipped with advanced engine control unit (ECU) calibration technology that automatically adapts to varying ethanol blends, enabling operation on fuels containing between 20 per cent and nearly 100 per cent ethanol. Maruti Suzuki said the Wagon R was chosen for the technology rollout because of its strong legacy in alternative-fuel mobility, including CNG and LPG variants.

Launching the vehicle, Union Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari said India's heavy dependence on imported crude oil makes biofuels such as ethanol crucial for enhancing energy security and supporting the rural economy. He said flex-fuel vehicles could create sustained demand for ethanol, benefiting farmers, industry and the environment.

Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri described India's ethanol programme as "unstoppable", saying it has helped transform farmers into energy producers while reducing dependence on imported fuel.

Maruti Suzuki Managing Director and CEO Hisashi Takeuchi said the company is pursuing multiple technologies, including battery electric vehicles, hybrids, CNG/CBG and flex-fuel vehicles, to help cut oil imports and carbon emissions.

He noted that India's ethanol ecosystem is still evolving but said wider adoption of flex-fuel vehicles could lower fuel imports and provide an additional source of income for farmers. AGENCIES



CLOSER LOOK

- The vehicle is equipped with advanced ECU calibration tech that automatically adapts to varying ethanol blends
- 'Wagon R was chosen for technology rollout because of its strong legacy in alternative-fuel mobility'
- 'Flex-fuel vehicles could create sustained demand for ethanol, benefiting farmers, industry & the environment'

Goldman Sachs buys over 1.13 cr shares of Groww for ₹210 crore

Shares of Groww rose 0.64% to Rs 190.05 apiece on BSE

NEW DELHI: Global financial services firm Goldman Sachs on Thursday bought more than 1.13 crore shares of Billionbrains Garage Ventures, the parent company of Groww, from venture capital firm Friale for Rs 210 crore through an open market transaction.

Goldman Sachs, through its affiliate Goldman Sachs Bank Europe SE, purchased 1,13,43,750 equity shares, representing a 0.18 per cent stake in the Bengaluru-based trading platform, according to block deal data available on the BSE.

The shares were picked up at an average price of Rs 185.50 apiece, taking the deal value to Rs 210.43 crore.

Meanwhile, Friale offloaded the same number of shares, as per the data.

Shares of Groww rose 0.64 per cent to close at Rs 190.05 apiece on the BSE.

On Monday, markets regulator Sebi approved US-based State Street Global Advisors' (SSGA) proposed stake acquisition in Groww Asset Management (Groww AMC), a wholly-owned subsidiary of Billionbrains Garage Ventures.

Following the proposed transaction, SSGA will acquire shares in Groww AMC and, upon completion of the deal, will hold voting rights of 4.85 per cent and an economic interest of 22.94 per cent in the fully diluted share capital of the asset manager. PTI

'India to implement 2-3 FTAs in 6 mnths, 3-4 more in 2027'

In the last three-and-half years, India has finalised nine FTAs, Commerce & Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India will implement at leat 2-3 free trade agreements (FTAs) over the next six months, while another 3-4 such pacts are expected to come into force in 2027, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Thursday.

He said that in the last three-and-a-half years, India has finalised nine FTAs including with Mauritius, New Zealand, the UAE, Australia, Oman, EFTA bloc, the UK, European Union and the US.

Trade deals with Mauritius, the UAE, Australia, Oman, and EFTA bloc have already been implemented. Separate deals with the UK and New Zealand have been signed.

"On the 1st of June, the Oman-FTA came into effect. In the coming six months, you will see at least two or three more very substantive free trade agreements coming into effect.

"Over the next year, you will see us executing at least another three or four significant free trade agreements and the coming into effect of all the nine free trade agreements over the next nine to ten months," Goyal said.

He also urged industry to invest long-term capital as the early capital will obviously get the best of returns.

The minister was speaking virtually at the Citi India Conference 2026 in Mumbai.

Talking about the West Asia crisis, he said in the field of energy, the world has seen how India navigated the global crisis over the last few months.

When the world is facing severe inflation, India has been able to moderate it, he said.

"When the world feared a crisis, given our independence on the Gulf and the energy flowing from the Gulf passing through the Strait of Hormuz and also our major supplies coming from the Gulf, some of which have been badly affected and damaged during this West Asia crisis, India having already initiated the process of diversification of energy sources was quickly able to meet the needs of our countrymen so that through this crisis, we have been able to ensure uninterrupted supplies whether it is petrol and diesel, or aviation fuel, whether it's LNG to the factories, LPG to the domestic consumers," he added.

India, he said, has been able to ensure modest prices.

The country continues to ensure availability of fertilizer to farmers, the minister said.


Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal

Trade deals with Mauritius, the UAE, Australia, Oman, and EFTA bloc have already been implemented. Separate deals with the United Kingdom and New Zealand have been signed

Highlights

- » 'On the 1st of June, the Oman-FTA came into effect. In the coming six months, you will see at least two or three more very substantive free trade agreements coming into effect'
- » He also urged industry to invest long-term capital as the early capital will obviously get the best of returns
- » Talking about the West Asia crisis, he said in the field of energy, the world has seen how India navigated the global crisis over the last few months

Markets end flat ahead of RBI's monetary policy decision & uncertainty in West Asia

From the 30-Sensex firms, Titan, Eternal, ITC, Tech Mahindra, State Bank of India (SBI) and ICICI Bank were among the major gainers

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty ended almost flat in a choppy trade on Thursday, as investors stayed on the sidelines amid uncertainty in West Asia and relentless foreign fund outflows.

Caution also prevailed in the market ahead of the RBI's monetary policy decision on Friday, an expert said.

The 30-share BSE Sensex went up marginally by 13.84 points, or 0.02 per cent, to settle at 74,360.01. During the day, it hit a high of 74,544.24 and a low of 73,807.30, gyrating 736.94 points.

The 50-share NSE Nifty eked out a marginal gain of 10.95 points, or 0.05 per cent, to end at 23,416.55.

From the 30-Sensex firms, Titan, Eternal, ITC, Tech Mahindra, State Bank of India (SBI) and ICICI Bank were among the major gainers.

Infosys, Bajaj Finserv, UltraTech Cement, HCL Tech and Adani Ports were among the laggards.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth Rs 5,616.56 crore on Wednesday, according to exchange data.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, declined 1.68 per cent to $96.17 per barrel.

The BSE SmallCap Select index jumped 1.02 per cent, and the MidCap Select index climbed 0.40 per cent.

Among indices, Consumer Durables climbed 1.94 per cent, Capital Goods (1.01 per cent), Telecom (0.82 per cent), Consumer Discretionary (0.72 per cent), Oil & Gas (0.57 per cent) and Power (0.41 per cent).

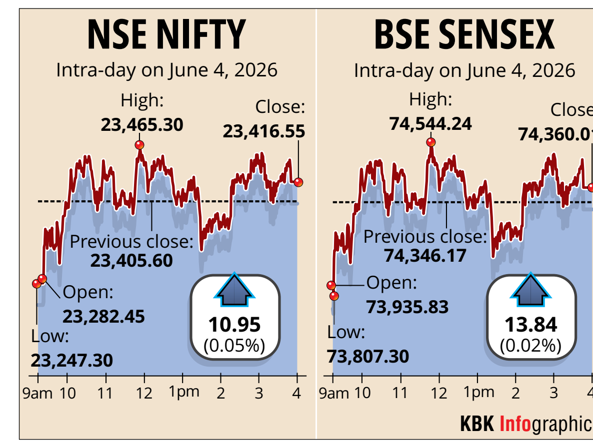
Metal declined 0.85 per cent, Commodities (0.49 per cent), IT (0.48 per cent), MidSmall Private Banks Quality Tilt (0.44 per cent) and Focused IT (0.02 per cent).

"Markets traded with a cautious tone on Thursday and ended largely unchanged on the weekly expiry day for the Sensex. Weak global cues and caution ahead of the MPC monetary policy announcement kept participants on the sidelines. Elevated crude oil prices and volatile global risk appetite further weighed on sentiment, although buying in select heavyweight stocks helped limit the downside," Ajit Mishra, SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

According to Ponmudi R, CEO of Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, the Israel-Lebanon ceasefire improved hopes for a wider diplomatic breakthrough involving Iran, but the continued closure of the Strait of Hormuz and the absence of tangible progress in negotiations kept investors in a wait-and-watch mode.

"The Nifty opened with a gap-down but gradually recovered through the session, managing to close marginally in positive territory," he said.

On Wednesday, the Sensex dropped 303.67 points, or 0.41 per cent, to settle at 74,346.17. The Nifty declined 77.95 points, or 0.33 per cent, to end at 23,405.60.



Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth Rs 5,616.56 crore on Wednesday, according to exchange data

Key Points

- » The BSE SmallCap Select index jumped 1.02 per cent, and the MidCap Select index climbed 0.40 per cent
- » Metal declined 0.85%, Commodities (0.49%), IT (0.48%), MidSmall Pvt Banks Quality Tilt (0.44%) & Focused IT (0.02%)
- » Consumer Durables jumped 1.94%, Capital Goods (1.01%), Telecom (0.82%), Consumer Discretionary (0.72%), Oil & Gas (0.57%), Power (0.41%)

Rupee rises 2 paise to 95.74 against dollar

MUMBAI: The rupee rose 2 paise to settle at 95.74 against the US dollar on Thursday, as the global crude oil prices eased and market participants keenly awaited the RBI's MPC decision on June 5.

Forex traders said the prolonged West Asia crisis poses a major risk for India, which relies heavily on energy imports.

Market participants are now turning their attention to the Reserve Bank of India's MPC rate decision on June 5, as inflation, growth and the rupee are under focus.

The six-member MPC, headed by RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra, will announce its decision on June 5.

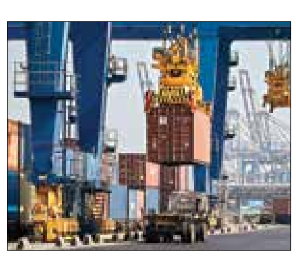
At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.70 against the US dollar, then touched an intra-day low of 95.87 and a high of 95.59 before closing at 95.74, up 2 paise from its previous close.

On Wednesday, the rupee depreciated 40 paise to close at 95.76 against the US dollar.

Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 99.31, down 0.21 per cent. PTI

India should reassess FTAs and move toward sector-based investment screening: Report

NEW DELHI: India should reassess the effectiveness of its existing Free Trade Agreements (FTAs), modernise its investment screening architecture, and adopt a more coordinated trade and industrial policy framework as geopolitical fragmentation reshapes global commerce, a report said on Thursday.



The report said that India's economic strategy must move beyond reactive policymaking and focus on proactive integration through calibrated partnerships, stronger institutional coordination and clearer market access objectives.

Among its key recommendations, the report calls on India to audit existing FTAs, assess whether they have met intended objectives, and align future trade agreements more closely with industrial and export priorities.

It also recommended that India explore high-quality market arrangements and utilise multilateral institutions and bilateral investment treaties to secure greater predictability for businesses and investors.

The report titled 'Resilience in a Fragmenting World: India's Economic Relations with Great Powers' is released by Koan Advisory Group, in association with Chintan Research Foundation, the Information Technology Industry Council, and the Institute of Chinese Studies.

"Trade agreements cannot be treated as ends in themselves. India needs a clearer understanding of what each agreement delivers in terms of market access, supply-chain resilience and industrial capacity. In a more uncertain and protectionist world, evaluating whether our free trade agreements have met their objectives becomes even more important," said Shishir Priyadarshi, president, Chintan Research Foundation.

The report also addresses the contested question about economic engagement with China amid strategic competition and manufacturing dependence.

Rather than relying solely on geography-based restrictions, participants recommended a sector-specific and national-security-led investment screening framework, coupled with a phased strategy to reduce dependence on Chinese inputs where vulnerabilities exist, it said.

India's manufacturing ambitions, particularly in electronics, clean energy and advanced technologies, remain linked to global supply chains that include Chinese capital and components, it said.

The report recommends utilising Chinese investment and technology in non-strategic sectors while strengthening screening mechanisms in genuinely sensitive areas. PTI

Fisheries Secy reviews broodstock, seed production for aquaculture

VISAKHAPATNAM: Union Fisheries Secretary Dr. Abhilaksh Likhi on Thursday visited the MPEDA-RCCA Brood Multiplication Centre (BMC) for Penaeus monodon and the ICAR-CMFRI Marine Fish Broodstock and Hatchery facility in Visakhapatnam to review efforts aimed at strengthening quality broodstock and seed production for the aquaculture sector.

During the visit, he interacted with scientists, technical experts, farmers and staff to assess ongoing research and broodstock development initiatives supporting India's shrimp aquaculture industry.

Stakeholders highlighted challenges including weak market linkages, high input and electricity costs, and the need for greater training and capacity building.

Dr. Likhi directed the Department of Fisheries to work with the National Fisheries Development Board and the Andhra Pradesh government to organise training programmes for farmers and stakeholders.

The Brood Multiplication Centre is expected to boost domestic production of Specific Pathogen Free (SPF) black tiger shrimp broodstock, reducing dependence on imports while improving biosecurity, productivity and sustainability.

The visit comes as India's marine product exports reached a record Rs 73,890.46 crore ($8.45 billion) in 2025-26.

Officials said the review reinforces the government's focus on self-reliance, species diversification and enhancing the global competitiveness of India's seafood sector. MPOST

Russia says its gold mining output overtakes China

MOSCOW: Russia has announced that its gold production has reached levels that surpass China, underscoring the country's expanding presence in the global precious metals market.

Russian officials attributed the increase to the expansion of mining operations, investments in new projects, and the adoption of advanced extraction technologies. The government has been focusing on developing mineral resources to strengthen economic resilience and increase export earnings.

The rise in output comes amid sustained global demand for gold, with central banks and investors continuing to view the metal as a safe-haven asset against inflation, economic uncertainty, and geopolitical tensions. Higher production could further bolster Russia's position in international gold markets and support its foreign exchange reserves.

Industry analysts note that competition among leading gold-producing nations remains strong, with countries such as China, Australia, and Canada continuing to invest in exploration and mining development.

Russia's latest announcement highlights the strategic role of gold in economic planning and resource management as nations seek to secure critical mineral assets. AGENCIES

Lufthansa welcomes visa-free airport transit for Indians via Germany

NEW DELHI: The Lufthansa Group welcomes the decision of the Federal Republic of Germany to abolish airport transit visa requirements for Indian nationals travelling to third countries via German airports, effective June 3, 2026.

This policy change, announced by the Embassy of the Federal Republic of Germany in New Delhi, will make journeys via key German hubs more seamless for Indian passengers and further strengthen air connectivity between India, Germany and the rest of the world.

As the largest European airline group in India, the Lufthansa Group currently operates more than 70 weekly flights between India and Europe and has been present in the Indian market for over six decades. In its 100th anniversary year, the Group is further deepening its commitment to India through sustained investment and network expansion.

This includes the deployment of Lufthansa's award-winning Allegris cabins on additional Boeing 787-9 services from Delhi and Hyderabad, the launch of SWISS's first-ever direct service between Bengaluru and Zurich in the 2026 Winter schedule, and the rollout of FOX (Future Onboard Experience) across all long-haul cabins. FOX is a premium upgrade across all cabins, focused on choice, comfort and individuality, delivering "Lufthansa Signature Moments" that aim to redefine long-haul travel. To meet growing demand, Lufthansa and SWISS are also adding capacity with extra SWISS A330 frequencies between Delhi and Zurich and enhanced Lufthansa Airbus A380 services between Mumbai and Munich.

India is the Lufthansa Group's largest intercontinental market in the Asia-Pacific region. The introduction of visa-free airport transit for Indian nationals travelling via Germany to onward destinations will simplify travel, improve connectivity and further reinforce Germany's role as a leading gateway between India, Europe and the world. MPOST

HDFC MF temporarily ristricts investments in Gold ETFs & Fund of Fund

NEW DELHI: HDFC Mutual Fund has temporarily restricted fresh investments in its gold exchange-traded fund (ETF) & gold ETF fund of fund (FoF), citing broader economic and market conditions. With this, HDFC Mutual Fund has become the first mutual fund house to restrict such subscriptions.

In an addendum issued on Thursday, the fund house said subscription transactions by large investors directly into HDFC Gold ETF will not be accepted from June 8.

The restriction will apply to investors making investments of at least Rs 25 crore directly with the fund house.

For HDFC Gold ETF Fund of Fund, lump-sum purchases and switch-ins will be processed only up to Rs 10 lakh per PAN per calendar month at the first-holder level.

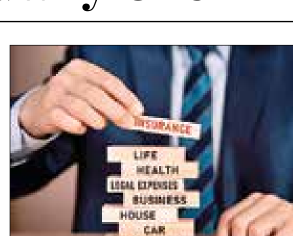
The limit for the FoF will be applicable to transactions received after the cut-off time of 3 pm on June 5, the fund house said.

HDFC Mutual Fund said the measures have been taken "in light of the broader economic and market conditions", and will remain in force until further notice. PTI

'India's insurance market to grow 10.7% annually over next decade'

NEW DELHI: India's insurance market is projected to expand at an average annual rate of 10.7 per cent over the next decade, outpacing the country's expected nominal GDP growth of 10.1 per cent, driven by demographic shifts, rising life expectancy and gaps in social protection, according to a report by Allianz Research.

The report said regulatory measures, including the vision of "Insurance for All by 2047" of the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) and recent market reforms, are expected to strengthen growth, efficiency and long-term stability in the sector.



Despite being among the world's ten largest insurance markets, India remains significantly underinsured, with insurance penetration at 3.8 per cent of GDP.

Only about 46 per cent of the working-age population is effectively covered by pension systems, while healthcare spending continues to be largely funded out of pocket.

The Indian insurance industry recorded strong growth in 2025, with total premium income rising 9.4 per cent to $146 billion from $133 billion in 2024.

Life insurance, accounting for 74 per cent of total premiums, grew 9.7 per cent, while property and casualty insurance expanded 7.5 per cent.

Health insurance emerged as the fastest-growing segment, registering 10.4 per cent growth amid high medical inflation and gaps in public healthcare coverage. AGENCIES

Central Bank eyes ₹3,500 cr bad loan recovery in FY27

FY26 recoveries from written-off loans stood at ₹2,270 crore, said MD & CEO Kalyan Kumar

NEW DELHI: State-owned Central Bank of India is aiming to mobilise over Rs 3,500 crore from recovery from bad loans as part of measures to improve its balance sheet during FY27.

"We are having about Rs 32,000 crore in technical written-off account. In FY26, the bank recovered Rs 2,270 crore from written-off loan accounts. We are expecting Rs 2,300-2,500 crore recovery from written off loans during this financial year too and it will play an important role in improvement in our bottom line," Central Bank of India MD & CEO Kalyan Kumar said.

CLOSER LOOK

- » During the financial year, he said, total recovery should be anywhere between Rs 3,500 crore & Rs 4,000 crore
- » The bank had made total recovery of Rs 3,307 crore during financial year ended March 2026
- » Kumar further said the bank plans to roll out wealth management and credit card business in the second half of the current fiscal to ramp up its fee income

During the financial year, he said, total recovery should be anywhere between Rs 3,500 crore and Rs 4,000 crore.

The bank had made total recovery of Rs 3,307 crore during financial year ended March 2026.

The Mumbai-headquartered bank has launched special One Time Settlement schemes, especially for Agri accounts and also intensified recovery campaigns, including property expos and SARFAESI action.

Kumar further said the bank plans to roll out wealth management and credit card business in the second half of the current fiscal to ramp up its fee income.

The bank has obtained board approval for the same.

"Now, we are in the process of issuing RFP (Request for Proposal) for onboarding those who are having expertise so that...we can start this business. In this year, I understand by middle of the year we should be in a position to launch this business," he said.

Besides, he said, the bank is planning to launch other products that can improve the non-interest income.

For corporate customers, he said, "cash management services play a very important role. That product is under development with us and by August, we are going to launch it...We are having centralized forex sale through that LC (Letter of Credit) and LG (Letter of Guarantee) business and also forex business we are starting."

To begin with, Kumar said, the bank would target its own corporate customers who are availing these facilities from other banks. PTI

From Russia, without love

Andreeva tops politically-charged contest to reach final

PARIS: Russian teenager Mirra Andreeva reached her first Grand Slam final by beating Marta Kostyuk of Ukraine 6-1, 6-3 at the French Open on Thursday.

The 19-year-old Andreeva converted her first match point when serving for the match. There was no post-match handshake between them and Kostyuk walked off quickly, turning only to wave and blow kisses to the crowd on Court Philippe-Chatrier, which saw some fans draped in Ukrainian flags. "I am happy that I am in my first ever Grand Slam final. All of these feelings combined, it is amazing," Andreeva said. "I just told myself no matter what happens, I am going to fight and give my best. With this kind of mindset, I ended up winning."

The atmosphere beforehand was somewhat tense as the players had separate photos taken as they each stood next to two children on their respective side of the net. Usually the players pose for the same photo, standing right next to each other by the net.

Kostyuk and countrywoman Oleksandra Oliynykova have spoken out during the tournament about the impact Russia's invasion of Ukraine is having on their country.

Andreeva saved three break points at 0-40 in her opening service game, then raced into a 4-0 lead with a flurry of blistering forehand winners. There was a big cheer when Kostyuk held serve in the fifth game, but the Ukrainian then handed Andreeva the first set when her backhand hit the net.

Meanwhile, after defeating No. 25 seed Diana Shnaider, 7-6(4) 6-4 in 2 hours and 10 minutes, 24-year-old Maja Chwalinska became the first qualifier in tournament history to reach the final. AGENCIES

Mirra Andreeva scored a 6-1 6-3 win over Marta Kostyuk AP

3

Andreeva, 19, becomes the third-youngest Roland Garros finalist of the 21st century

Serena and Mboko to team up

LONDON: Serena Williams will make her eagerly anticipated return to professional tennis playing doubles alongside a partner who is 25 years younger.

Victoria Mboko, the 19-year-old Canadian ranked No. 9, revealed Thursday she would have the "honor" of playing with the 44-year-old Williams as wild-card entries at the Queen's Club next week.

They practiced on the grass courts in west London on Thursday, with Williams seen hitting balls in a purple top and white pants.

"The Queen is back," Mboko wrote in a post on Instagram alongside a picture of her standing next to Williams. "An honor to share the court with one of the greatest athletes of all time this week," Mboko added. "Even more excited to play doubles together!"

Williams stepped away from tennis in 2022. AGENCIES

'WE NEED TO STICK TO A NO. 3'

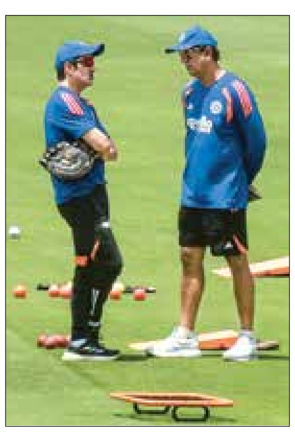
Sudharsan or Padikkal? End the No. 3 roulette, says ten Doeschate

MULLANPUR: India's assistant coach Ryan Ten Doeschate conceded that too many players have batted at No. 3 in Test matches after Cheteshwar Pujara's retirement and it was time that either Sai Sudharsan or Devdutt Padikkal is given a long rope at the key batting position.

Pujara announced his retirement in 2025 but last played in white flannels for India in the WTC final in 2023. Since then Shubman Gill, Padikkal, Sudharsan, Karun Nair and Washington Sundar have all been tried in that position.

Sudharsan has played six Tests and has managed a not-so-impressive average of 27 plus.

"There's been a lot of changes in that spot and and that's not ideal, you know. You need to look at the incumbents for that role and and maybe stick with someone," Ten Doeschate said at a press conference on Thursday.



Gautam Gambhir during a practice session on Tuesday PTI

While both Sudharsan and Padikkal have been getting long rope at nets, Ten Doeschate didnt want to spill the beans about the one who would make it.

On the day, during slip formation, Padikkal was seen standing alongside KL Rahul and skipper Shubman Gill. After Rahul went to the nets, Sudharsan came in.

During nets, Sudharsan once again lost the grip on his bat which slipped and flew backwards like it happened in IPL twice. "It's a difficult position to bat in and a very important position to bat in. Dev comes in with a ton of runs in domestic cricket across all the formats and obviously Sai's been high on runs in IPL with Gujarat, so they're both in good form," he said. AGENCIES

Sindhu out, Hariharan-Arjun pair in Indonesia last-8

JAKARTA: PV Sindhu suffered a second successive defeat to world No. 1 An Se Young in as many weeks to bow out of the Indonesia Open here on Thursday.

Sindhu, who had also lost to the South Korean in the quarterfinals of last week's Singapore Open, went down 17-21, 14-21 in the Round of 16.

The defeat extended Sindhu's losing streak against the her to 10 matches. Meanwhile, the men's doubles pair of Hariharan Amsakarunan and MR Arjun upset Malaysian duo of Aaron Tai and Kang Khai Xing 16-21, 21-15, 21-19 to reach their first ever World Tour Super 1000 quarters. AGENCIES

Kohli out of Afghan ODIs

HYDERABAD: Indian batting superstar Virat Kohli was on Thursday ruled out of the upcoming ODI series against Afghanistan due to a hamstring injury that he sustained during the recently-concluded IPL. The three-match series begins on June 13 in Dharamsala. "He is out of due to a hamstring injury. Scans revealed distal semimembranosus tendon tear," a BCCI source said. AGENCIES

Pragg opens up on Candidates debacle, says it still rankles

OSLO: Indian chess ace R Praggnanandhaa on Thursday admitted that it was hard to come to terms with missing out the Candidates Tournament title, having given "everything" to earn the right to challenge D Gukesh for the World Championship crown, only to be left deeply disappointed.

The 20-year-old Grandmaster was among the eight players who competed in the Candidates in Cyprus earlier this year but endured a disappointing campaign, finishing seventh as Uzbekistan's Javokhir Sindarov claimed the title and the right to face Gukesh for the world crown.

Praggnanandhaa now has an opportunity to put the Candidates disappointment behind him at Norway Chess, where he has emerged as a title contender, sitting third with two rounds remaining and just two points behind leader Wesley So. He can kickstart the new two-year World Championship cycle on a positive note with a title here. "Yeah, certainly that's (disappointment of not doing well in Candidates) is something that I have to deal with because in the last two years I was thinking only about this cycle... I sort of gave everything for this. There was nothing else I was thinking about," said the Chennai-based GM, reflecting on the disappointment of missing out in the Candidates.

"You can also see from the tournaments I played last year that I was just going for this (Candidates qualification)... one spot in FIDE circuit and it is disappointing the way it ends like this. But, yeah, it is what it is. I have to try and get back to playing tournaments," he added.

Praggnanandhaa said after investing so much time and energy into qualifying for the Candidates, he now wants to rediscover the joy of the game without constantly looking ahead to the next qualification race. "After the Candidates, I felt like I just want to enjoy chess now. I just want to play and have fun. Last year, I was just going for that one thing but now I feel I don't want to think about the next cycle...all the way from now I just want to chill and enjoy chess," he said. AGENCIES

millenniumpost
FRIDAY, 5 JUNE, 2026 | NEW DELHI

PARAMVIR OPENS UP ABOUT 'THE PYRAMID SCHEME'

'I've actually experienced this world firsthand,' says Cheema

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Ever since 'Prime Video' unveiled the trailer for 'The Pyramid Scheme', audiences have been quite intrigued about the world it inhabits, where ambition, influence and the promise of quick success can change lives overnight. At the heart of the story is Goldy, played by Paramvir Singh Cheema, a charismatic young man determined to have quick wealth and an easy path to success and to build a better future through 'Jumbolife', a pyramid marketing company, only to find himself drawn into a system that blurs the line between aspiration and deception.

However, this unconventional story hit close to home for Paramvir. Ahead of The Pyramid Scheme's global premiere on June 5, the actor recalls falling for a similar trap that promised easy money and quick returns.

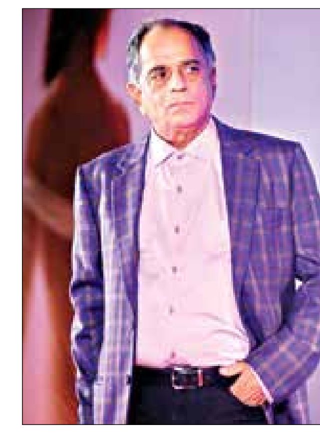
Opening up about his own brush with such a scheme, Paramvir revealed, "Someone in my locality was into this and I am one of them. You could say I was one of the victims. At that time, I was young, must've been in my early 20s. A neighbour approached me saying, 'Param, this is how it works: you invest money and you'll make money in return. When you're young and don't have a lot of money, it all sounds very exciting. It felt like I could invest a little money and earn money without doing much. It felt like a great idea at the time. But after a while, that person stopped responding and I remember thinking, 'What is going on here?' When I told my father about it, he just laughed and said, 'Why are you getting yourself into these kinds of things?' So yes, I've actually experienced this world firsthand."

> 'The Pyramid Scheme' also stars Ranvir Shorey, Shekhar Suman, Aanjjan Srivastav and others in pivotal roles

Sharing some insights about his character, Goldy, he added, "Goldy is very reactive. He reacts to every situation and every emotion around him. Even if someone gives him a look, his immediate thought is, 'Why did he look at me like that?'"

Pahlaj Nihalani passes away at 76

He was the veteran producer and former chairperson of the Central Board of Film Certification



Pahlaj Nihalani, the veteran producer and former chairperson of the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC), died on Thursday, his friend Shashi Ranjan said. He was 76.

Born on January 10, 1950, Nihalani started his career as a producer with the 1982 movie 'Haathkadi'. He is widely credited for giving actor Govinda his first big break with the 1986 movie 'Ilzaam'. He also introduced actor Chunky Panday with 'Aag Hi Aag' in 1987.

Nihalani's other producing credits include 'Shola Aur Shabnam', 'Aankhen', 'Dil Tera Diwana', 'Talaash' and 'Rangeela Raja'.

In January 2015, Nihalani was appointed as the chairperson of the Central Board of Film Certification. His tenure, which lasted until August 2017, was riddled with controversies and was marked by frequent run-ins with filmmakers over cuts, disclaimers and certification decisions.

During his stint, he introduced strict new guidelines barring certain expletives even in 'A'-rated films, trimmed kissing scenes and sought to restrict content that could be seen as hurting religious sentiments or depicting violence. Critics in the film fraternity frequently accused him of overreach, while he maintained he was simply doing his job.

> He is widely credited for giving Govinda his first big break with the 1986 movie 'Ilzaam'

Shashi Shekhar Vempati, the current chairperson of the CBFC, condoled his death in a post on 'X'. "Heartfelt condolences from the entire CBFC family on the demise of former CBFC Chairperson Shri Pahlaj Nihalani," he wrote.

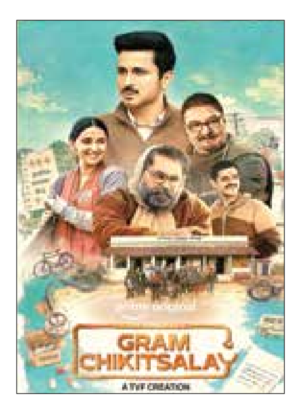
He is survived by his wife, Nita Nihalani and his three sons. His last rites will take place at Santacruz Hindu Crematorium. PTI

'Gram Chikitsalay' S2 to globally premiere on June 23

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Prime Video' announced June 23 as the worldwide premiere date for the highly anticipated second season of its 'Prime Original' series 'Gram Chikitsalay'. Set in the fictional village of Bhathkandi, the heartwarming comedy drama continues to explore the harsh realities of healthcare in rural India, laced with humour and emotion, capturing the resilience, warmth and quirks of village life.

The series returns with Amol Parashar, Akash Makhija, Anandeshwar Dwivedi, Vinay Pathak, Akansha Ranjan Kapoor and Garima Vikrant Singh reprising their roles, with Dinesh Lal Yadav joining the series.



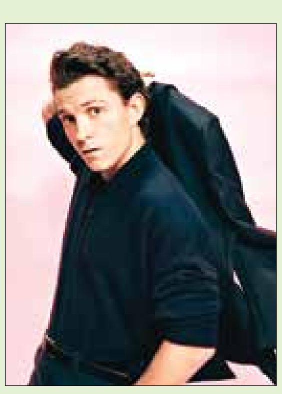
Picking up from where season one ended, the newest instalment follows Dr Prabhat (Amol Parashar) as he continues his mission to revive the struggling Primary Health Centre in Bhathkandi. While he gradually earns the trust of the villagers despite their scepticism, new challenges continue to emerge at every step. The story delves deeper into the clash between idealism and reality, as Dr Prabhat learns that running a rural healthcare centre requires far more than just medical knowledge.

"As audience preferences continue to evolve, we are seeing a growing appetite not just for authentic urban narratives, but increasingly for stories rooted in rural India as well. 'Gram Chikitsalay' reflected this trend through its slice-of-life storytelling and emotionally resonant themes. Following the overwhelming response to the first season, we are delighted to bring audiences the next journey of this rural comedy drama that continues to blend emotion, realism and social commentary. The series marks another important chapter in our longstanding association with 'The Viral Fever', with whom we share a vision of bringing culturally rooted and emotionally engaging stories," said Manish Menghani, Director & Head of Content licensing, 'Prime Video, India'.

DELAYING 'SPIDER-MAN' FOR 'THE ODYSSEY'?

Tom recalls 'uncomfortable conversation' with Sony

Hollywood star Tom Holland said he requested 'Sony' to postpone the production of 'Spider-Man: Brand New Day' so he could start working on Christopher Nolan's directorial 'The Odyssey'.



The actor recalled his conversation with 'Sony Pictures' boss Tom Rothman. "So, I said to Chris, like, 'Look, I want to do this movie, but if I'm going to do it, I'm going to have to call 'Sony' and have a very uncomfortable conversation," he told 'GQ' in an interview.

He added, "I think one of the reasons why 'Sony' was happy to move is because Chris has that reputation of, 'This movie isn't going to go five months over and we aren't actually going to lose Tom for two years... Any other director, it might have been a slightly different conversation."

> The Hollywood actor said that the break also allowed the makers to bring Destin Daniel Cretton, who replaced Jon Watts

The actor said the break also allowed the makers to bring Destin Daniel Cretton, who replaced Jon Watts, the director of the first three MCU 'Spider-Man' films, who stepped away from the franchise.

"'The Odyssey' almost saved 'Spider-Man' because we wouldn't have had Destin... He wouldn't have been ready to make the movie when we were ready to go. We wouldn't have had the six-month period to develop the script with Destin to get it to the place where it is now. And I truly believe that we've made the best version of any 'Spider-Man' movie going. So, while it was a tough pill to swallow for 'Sony', I think in hindsight, they're very grateful that it happened," he said. PTI

Felt like I cheated death: Emilia Clarke

The actress opened up about surviving two brain surgeries

Game of Thrones' star Emilia Clarke, who survived two brain surgeries while shooting for the globally popular series, said for years, she felt like she had cheated death.

Clarke, who was honoured at Variety's Power of Women London, presented by 'Lifetime', said the health scare led her to find the charity 'SameYou' in 2019 with her mother.

"For a number of years, I felt that I had cheated death and it was coming to get me. I truly felt like I had done something wrong and I shouldn't be here. I also thought it ruined my ability to act, which some people might agree with," the actress said during her speech.

Clarke first opened up about her health in 2019 and said she was overwhelmed by the response of the people who reached out to her. "Today we have tens of thousands of survivors in our community saying essentially the same thing: the journey to healing feels like falling off the edge of a cliff without anyone there to catch you."

> The 'Game of Thrones' star first opened up about her health in 2019

The 'Game of Thrones' star was honoured alongside Emma Corrin, Hannah Waddingham, Suki Waterhouse and Cynthia Erivo. In past interviews, Clarke spoke about how she went through two lifesaving brain operations in 2011 and in 2013 to treat aneurysms.

Clarke became a globally renowned actor with her role of dragon queen Daenerys Targaryen. PTI